SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · BOOK 3

# Understanding Each Other

*How we hear, see and belong to each other, at home and in every group*



*by Christian*

Spread Love & Acceptance
spreadloveandacceptance.com

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**Not therapy.** This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

**If you are not safe.** If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

**The examples are made up.** The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed in short at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

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# Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-03 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as “Workpaper WP-03: One owner per job”. Every workpaper is free to print or fill in on the website: the book names it and gives a code to scan. *The Workpapers: Free Forms, All in One* has them all in one place, on big pages.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as “Tool: Chat analyzer”. You use it and it gives you something back.

*The book keeps the two apart: a workpaper and a tool never share a list. Both are free, need no account, and what you type stays on your device.*

## THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



**Professor Puddles**, the cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints.



**Tidbit**, the quick, curious pup, bounds in with a playful tip.



**Sugarfoot**, the steady, gentle pup, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

*They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.*

# If you need help now

**If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number:** 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

| WHERE YOU ARE | CALL OR TEXT |
|---|---|
| **United States** | Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line). |
| **United Kingdom** | Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line). |
| **Ireland** | Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. |
| **Canada** | Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French. |
| **Australia** | Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14. |
| **New Zealand** | Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?). |
| **Anywhere else** | **findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat. |

## For children and young people

| | |
|---|---|
| **UK** | Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19) |
| **Ireland** | Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18) |

| | |
|---|---|
| **Canada** | Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868 |
| **Australia** | Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25) |
| **New Zealand** | Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234 |
| **US** | 988 is for every age. |

## If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Part Three, Chapter 12, page **117** says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Chapter 16 (online) about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

# 1

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 1 · ONLINE: PART TWO · CHAPTER I

# Why we get out of tune: communication at home

*Why two kind, reasonable people can end up in a tangle neither of them started, and how to get back in step.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. The tangle often isn't about the words
2. Nearly in step is the noisy part
3. Three things knock you out of tune
4. Stress changes your station
5. Nobody has to be wrong
6. Get back in tune before you carry on
7. Go back in with a clear sentence
8. Small daily check-ins keep you in tune
9. Faith, culture and family voices
10. Inside you, and between you
11. On your own: your side of the tuning
12. The fields behind this chapter
13. In real life
14. More kinds of shared life
15. Common mix-ups


IN SHORT:

- **A clash often isn't about the words.** Pace, tone and urgency can be out of step even when both of you mean well.
- **Nobody has to be wrong.** Name it ("we're out of tune"), pause with a time to come back, and slow down.
- **Go back in with one clear sentence:** a fact, a feeling and an ask.
- **A 90-second daily check-in** keeps small drifts small.

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

*"I said I'd do it." "I know, I'm just asking when." Four sentences later, nobody is talking about the bins any more, and neither of you can point to the moment it turned.*

01

## The tangle often isn't about the words.

Two people can each say something reasonable and still clash, because the tone underneath doesn't match. It's like two radios slightly out of tune: together they make a crackle that neither one was making alone.

*For example:* Two housemates. "Is anyone using the oven tonight?" "Why, did I leave a mess?" A plain question was heard as a complaint.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

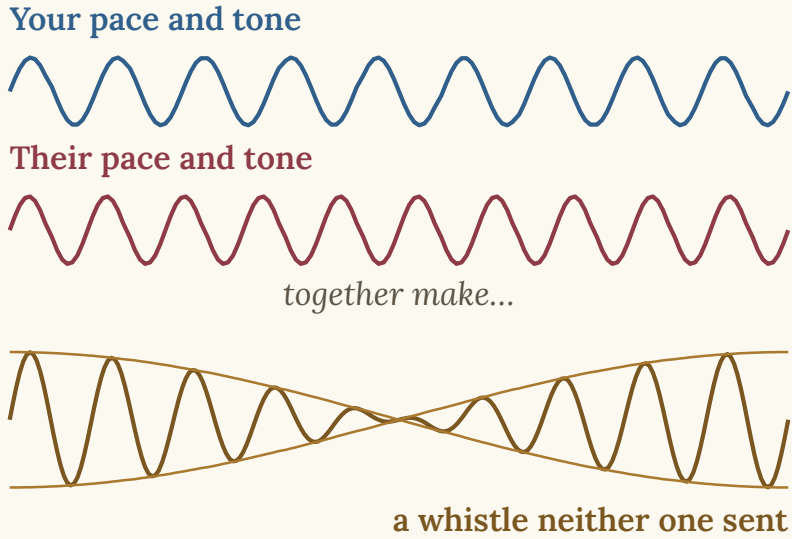
"I think the words were fine. Something in how we said them got crossed."

TRY THIS:

After your next small clash, ask yourself: was it the words, or the way they came out?

## The radio whistle

*Two reasonable signals, nearly in step.*




**Not “you started it” or “I started it”.**
*It started, between us.*

*Illustration. The picture is borrowed from radio (a “beat” between two close frequencies). Using it for people is this book’s idea.*

FIGURE 1 The radio whistle. Two reasonable signals, nearly in step, can make a clash that neither person started: it started between you.

02

### Nearly in step is the noisy part.

Radios on very different stations don’t whistle at each other. The whistle comes when they are close but not quite matched. People who know each other well can still clash. Research suggests we check our meaning less with people we’re close to, because we assume they already understand us.

*For example*: Two sisters who talk every day clash over holiday plans far more than they ever do with cousins they see once a year. Being close means more overlap.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think I assumed you knew what I meant. Let me say it more clearly."

TRY THIS:

With someone close, check one meaning today: "Just so I've got it right, you mean…?"



TIDBIT

Ooh, Tidbit loves this one: compare your daily rhythms and see whose engine runs fast in the morning and whose at night. Different speeds aren't wrong, just different!

TOOL **Compare your daily rhythms** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration`

03

## Three things knock you out of tune.

How fast you're talking. The tone, when a simple update is heard as a complaint. And how urgent it feels: "when you get a chance" can mean tonight to one person and next week to the other.

*For example*: A business partner texts "Need to talk" between two meetings. The other partner reads it as a crisis and can't sleep. It was about a printer. A text loses most of the tone, so urgency is easy to misread.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"By when would be good?" "Is this an update, or a worry?"

TRY THIS:

Add a time to your next request. Not "at some point," but "by Friday."

04

### Stress changes your station.

When you're tense, you may talk faster and be more likely to hear a pause as a snub. When you're tired and flat, your replies get slower and shorter. The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks), a thirty-second self-check, helps you guess which one you're in. It's a best guess, not a reading.

*For example*: A dad gets home from a night shift and answers his teenager with one word. The teen hears "he doesn't care." He is just running on empty.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm running low right now. It's not about you. Can we talk after I've slept?"

TRY THIS:

Before a tricky talk, name your state to yourself: calm, revved up or running on empty.

05

### Nobody has to be wrong.

Two radios that both work fine will still crackle if they're slightly off. Arguing about whose fault the static is won't clear it. Retuning (getting back in step) will.

*For example*: A grandmother tells her grown-up son, "You look tired." She means care. He hears "you can't cope." Neither of them

is wrong about what they meant or heard.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I don't think either of us meant it that way. Can we try that again?"

> TRY THIS:
> In your next clash, say "we" instead of "you": "We got crossed there."

06

### Get back in tune before you carry on.

Say it out loud: "I think we're out of sync." Check how tense you feel. Either of you can call a pause, and the person who paused names a time to come back. Gently slow down, with shorter turns and more pauses. Only then go back to the actual topic.

*For example*: Two dorm roommates agree on a pause word, "static," on a calm day. Mid-argument about noise, one says it. They stop, and come back at 9pm as agreed.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I need ten minutes. I'll come back at half past."

> TRY THIS:
> Agree a pause word with someone today, while you are both calm.




FIGURE 2 Retuning, step by step, before you carry on with a talk that has started to whistle.

07

### Go back in with a clear sentence.

When you return to the topic, say the fact, how you feel, and what you'd like. "The bins go out early on Wednesday morning. I get anxious when they're late. Could you put them out tonight?"

*For example*: A co-parent texts: "The swim kit wasn't in the bag. I felt stressed at drop-off. Could you pack it on Sunday nights?" A fact, a feeling, an ask.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"The fact is... I feel... Could we...?"

TRY THIS:

Write one fact, feeling and ask sentence about something small, before you need it.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When you go back in, one clear sentence beats a speech. This workpaper helps you shape it before you say it.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

08

## Small daily check-ins keep you in tune.

A short chat each day, like the 90-second daily check-in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-13-daily-check-in), can make tiny corrections before small things drift into a big argument. Habit research suggests small routines at a regular time are easier to keep than big ones done rarely. The quiet, easy stretches are the ones that drift most, so keep it going even when nothing seems wrong (see Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency)).

*For example*: A long-distance couple in two time zones send one 90-second voice note each morning. It's tiny, but it keeps them in step.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Today I was carrying quite a lot. One thing I liked today was..."

TRY THIS:

Pick a time and a cue, like right after dinner, and try the check-in for three days.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

**The 90-second daily check-in**

*Priya and Dev, a couple on different shifts*

## The 90-second daily check-in

Person A
*Priya*

Person B
*Dev*

Week beginning
5 October 2026

### Each day

| Day | Person | Load | One thing I appreciated today | One small thing that didn't feel great | One thing that would help tomorrow |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | Priya | High | You left soup in the fridge before my night shift | Woke up to the washing still in the machine | A text when you're leaving work |
| Mon | Dev | Medium | Your note on the kettle | | Bins out before I go at six |
| Tue | Priya | High | You kept the house quiet till noon | | Ten minutes together at the shift change |
| Tue | Dev | Low | You booked the car in | Missed you at dinner again | |

| Day | Person | Load | One thing I appreciated today | One small thing that didn't feel great | One thing that would help tomorrow |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Wed* | *Priya* | *Medium* | *Breakfast together at 8* | | *Early night* |
| *Wed* | *Dev* | *Medium* | *You remembered my mum's call* | | |

LOAD THIS WEEK

**Priya**
2 high, 1 medium, 0 low

**Dev**
0 high, 2 medium, 1 low

### The weekly catch-up

| Sore spot that keeps coming up | Times this week | Move to |
|---|---|---|
| *Washing left in the machine* | 2 | *One owner per job* |
| *Missing each other at dinner* | 2 | *Keep watching* |

*A made-up example. Names and details are invented. One sentence each, then just listen: no debating, no solving.*

Fill in your own: The 90-second daily check-in
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You control what you send, whether you check how it landed, and whether you step out to retune. You don't control how it's heard or how fast the other person settles. Matching energy here means matching care and effort, never volume: if someone gets louder, you don't have to follow. Stay at your level, and give the conversation the energy it gives back. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

SATURDAY, 10AM

*"We should clear out the spare room at some point." One of you meant this month. The other heard today and has already cancelled their plans in their head. By lunchtime you're both upset about a room nobody has touched.*

## Faith, culture and family voices

For many couples, faith is where they turn first. If you share a faith, it can be one of your strongest tools for staying in tune.

- **A shared rhythm:** praying together, or a quiet moment after worship, can be your daily check-in.
- **A pause with a purpose:** some couples pray, each on their own, before they come back to a hard talk. The pause still has a time to come back.
- **Your community:** a pastor, imam, rabbi, priest or trusted elder can be a good first person to talk to. Many can also suggest a trained counsellor who shares your faith.

*For example (made up)*: Emeka and Ngozi, married 26 years, do their monthly look-back on a Sunday after church, over lunch.

When a talk gets heated, either of them can say, “Let’s pray on it and come back at eight.” And they do.

Culture shapes how you talk, too. In many families, respect for elders decides who can speak plainly to whom. One habit helps: each of you speaks to your own parents and relatives, after you’ve agreed the message together.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> “Can we pray about this and talk again tonight?” “Mum, we love you, and we’ve thought about it carefully. This year we’ll visit in August, not at Easter.”

From two faiths or cultures? See Two faiths or cultures, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths).

## Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** Know your own pace, your usual tone and what “soon” means to you. Notice when stress speeds you up or slows you down.
- **Between you and others:** When a clash starts, treat it as a tuning problem, not a moral failing. Retune together, then translate what you meant into words the other person can hear.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> “I think this is a tuning problem, not a you problem.” “What did you hear me say? I want to check it came out right.”

## On your own: your side of the tuning

Getting out of tune takes two, but retuning can start with one. You can learn your own pace, tone and urgency, so you notice when

you're the one running fast or slow.

- Learn your early signs of drifting: a tight chest, a clipped reply, wanting to win.
- Learn how you take words in best, and say it once: "I hear things better in writing."
- When you drift, step out, settle and come back. You don't need anyone's permission to retune yourself.

*For example:* Hamid lives alone and notices his texts to friends come out short when he's tired. Now he waits until morning to answer anything that matters.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm tired, so I might sound shorter than I mean. Can I reply properly tomorrow?"

> TRY THIS:
> For one day, notice the first sign in your body that you're drifting. Write it down. More for people on their own: On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

> IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:
> Step 2: get to know your wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Step 4: plan what settles you · Part One: who you are today · The whole book on talking it through (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-talk-it-through)

## The fields behind this chapter

This chapter draws on 5 of the author's thirteen fields (see the Preface (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface) or the About page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/about)):

- **Psychology** (Tune how you send and receive): The gap between intent and impact: why a clear, kind sentence can still land as an attack, once pace, tone or urgency slips.
- **Neurobiology** (Read your state first): How stress changes your frequency, and how you sound and hear.
- **Philosophy** (Fix the setup, not the person): Nobody has to be wrong. Zhuangzi's Empty Boat: much of the time, the bump was no one's plan.
- **Behavioural science** (Tune how you send and receive): Small and often. A small routine at a regular time is easier to keep.
- **Holistic therapies** (Read your state first): Body first, argument second. Settle your own state before you go back to the talk.

**Two fields, one idea: Neurobiology + Psychology.** A tired body changes how words sound and how they're heard. So the same sentence can be fine on Saturday and a fight on Tuesday. Check your state, then say it.

## In real life

- **Partners:** "Did you pay the gas bill?" is meant as a reminder. After a long day, it lands as "you forgot again."
- **Family:** A parent asks, "Are you coming on Sunday?" They mean it as a simple question. Their grown-up child hears guilt.
- **Roommates:** A message says, "Can we talk about the kitchen?" One roommate meant a quick chat. The other spends all afternoon worrying.
- **Coworkers:** "Quick question" arrives at 5:55pm. The sender meant tomorrow is fine. The reader thinks it's urgent and stays late.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I meant that as a question, not a complaint. Sorry it came out sharp."

## More kinds of shared life

Getting out of tune happens wherever people talk often:

- **Two dads:** "Did you call the school?" is a reminder to one and a test to the other.
- **Three partners:** two speak fast and one slowly, so the slow one gets talked over. More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two)
- **Friends:** a one-word reply after a long message reads as cold, when they were just busy. Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Gaming and phones:** "Five more minutes" means five to one person and a match to the other. Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together)
- **Teens and parents:** a parent's worry comes out fast and sounds like anger. For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Adult siblings:** after years apart, an old nickname lands like an old fight. Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- **Foster and kinship carers:** a child who has been hurt may hear a raised voice as danger, even when it isn't. Foster and kinship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)
- **Different hours, illness, two faiths:** a tired shift worker, a partner in pain, or two family styles of speaking can all shift the tune. Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours) · When one is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Two faiths

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

## Common mix-ups

- **"Retuning means giving in."** It doesn't. You still come back to the topic. You just come back when you can hear each other.
- **"If we're out of sync, one of us must be wrong."** Two fair points in two different tones can still clash.
- **"Slowing down means I don't care."** Slowing down is how you show you want to get it right.
- **"A pause means the topic is dropped."** A pause always comes with a time to come back.
- **"We should push through while we're on the subject."** Pushing on through static usually makes more static.

TRY THIS:

Next time a conversation starts to go wrong, pause and say so kindly, instead of pushing through.

Before then, agree on a shared phrase, like "I think we're out of tune." That way it feels like a signal, not a criticism.

For one week, each of you notes one moment you felt out of step. At the end, compare: was it mostly pace, tone or urgency?

When someone says "when you get a chance," kindly ask, "By when would be good?"

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think we're out of tune. Can we slow down?" "I want to get this right, so I'm going to go slower."

**A limit to keep in mind:** These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking things through ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A pause is for both of you. If one person is never allowed to pause, or a "pause" is used to punish with days of silence, that isn't retuning. Signs to look out for.

---

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **A clash often isn't about the words.** Pace, tone and urgency can be out of step even when both of you mean well.
- ✓ **Nobody has to be wrong.** Name it ("we're out of tune"), pause with a time to come back, and slow down.
- ✓ **Go back in with one clear sentence:** a fact, a feeling and an ask.
- ✓ **A 90-second daily check-in** keeps small drifts small.

## THIS CONNECTS TO

**Chapter 2 · How communication works**
*How meaning, tone and listening work*
page 25

**Book 2 · Stress and the nervous system**
*Why stress speeds people up or shuts them down*
Heal and Steady

**Book 1 · Your wiring, weather and words**
*How you like to be spoken to*
Know Yourself Kindly

**Book 1 · Minds that work differently**
*When pace and tone are a wiring difference*
Know Yourself Kindly

## PUT IT TO USE



**Six-week program, week 1**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



**The 90-second daily check-in**
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13



**Go deeper (free online)** The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1-in-depth

# 2

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 2 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 4

# How communication works: meaning, listening, repair and messages

*Talking feels simple, because we do it all day. But every message has to travel from one mind to another, and a lot can change on the way. This chapter explains how that journey works, and what helps a message arrive the way you meant it.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Meaning is made between two people
2. Every message says two things
3. Listening is something you do, not something that happens
4. Check, don't guess
5. Hard things land better when they start soft
6. Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill
7. Messages lose their tone on the way
8. Different styles aren't wrong styles
9. Small talk has a job, and it can be short
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation


IN SHORT:

- **Meaning is made between two people.** What you say and what they hear can be different, and nobody has to be wrong.
- **Every message says two things:** the words, and what they seem to say about the two of you.

- **Check, don't guess.** A short question saves a long misunderstanding.
- **Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill.** And small talk is allowed to be short.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **Say it so it lands** (Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) uses fact, feeling and one clear ask, because every message carries the content and a second message about the relationship. Big idea: *tune how you send and receive.*
- **The 90-second daily check-in and "go back in with a clear sentence"** (Part Two, Chapter I (page 7)) work because mix-ups are normal. Small, frequent repairs keep you in tune better than rare big talks.
- **The Chat analyzer's whole-conversation view (once called the Conversation Reader)** shows where a written conversation lost its tone, because messages lose tone on the way.

THURSDAY, 8:15AM

*"Can you call me when you're free?" Ana meant: no rush, I have a small question about the weekend. Her brother read it on the bus and spent the whole ride wondering who was ill. Nobody did anything wrong. The message just arrived carrying something it was never meant to carry.*

This chapter explains how a message travels from one mind to another, what can change on the way, and the small habits that help it arrive: listening, checking, starting soft, repairing, and a few ready-made lines for small talk.

01

## Meaning is made between two people.

Words don't carry meaning on their own. The person speaking has a meaning in mind. The person listening builds their own meaning from the words, the tone, the timing and everything they already expect. Most of the time the two match well enough. Sometimes they don't, and neither person can see the gap from where they stand.

*For example*: A manager writes "Let's chat tomorrow" to a new coworker. She means a friendly catch-up. He spends the evening sure he is in trouble.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I think what I meant and what you heard might be two different things. Can we check?"

> TRY THIS:
> Today, notice one moment when someone took your words differently from how you meant them. Just notice. No blame.

02

## Every message says two things.

There is *what* you say, and there is what it says about the two of you. "You're late" is a fact about time. It can also say "I was worried," or "I don't matter to you." People often argue about the fact when the hurt is in the second layer.

*For example*: Two housemates. “Did you use my pan?” is about a pan. Underneath, it may be “Do you respect my things?” Talking only about the pan won’t settle that.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

“I don’t really mind about the pan. I think I wanted to know my stuff matters here.”

TRY THIS:

Next time a small thing stings, ask yourself: what did that seem to say about *us*?

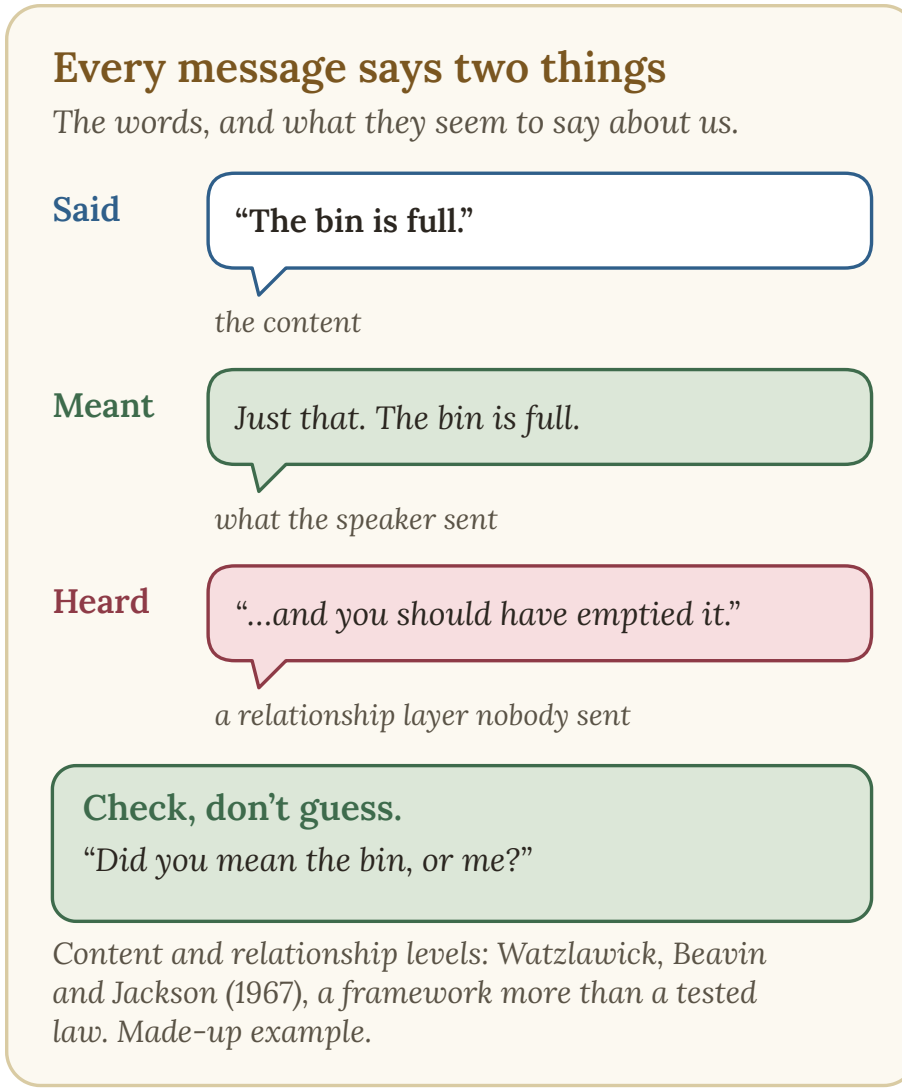



FIGURE 3 Every message says two things: the words, and what they seem to say about the two of you. Check, don't guess.

03

## Listening is something you do, not something that happens.

Hearing is automatic. Listening is a choice. Most of us listen partly to reply: to fix, defend, advise or tell our own story. Real listening means following what the other person is trying to say, and letting

them know you got it, before you add anything of your own.

*For example:* A teenager says school is "pointless." Her dad starts to explain why it isn't. She stops talking. Next time, he tries "Pointless how? Tell me about today." She talks for twenty minutes.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"So what I'm hearing is... Have I got that right?" "Do you want ideas, or do you want me to just listen?"

TRY THIS:

In one conversation today, wait until the other person has finished, then say back what you heard before you reply.

04

### Check, don't guess.

Once we know something, it's hard to imagine not knowing it. So we leave out steps, assume the other person can tell what we mean, and guess what they meant instead of asking. We do this most with people we know well. A short check costs a sentence. A wrong guess can cost a whole evening.

*For example:* Two friends plan "something low-key" for a birthday. One pictures a takeaway on the sofa. The other books a quiet restaurant. Both are disappointed, and both thought it was obvious.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Just so I've got it right, you mean...?" "When you say soon, do you mean today or this week?"

TRY THIS:

Pick one person you know well and check one meaning with them today, even if you feel sure.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Checking takes ten seconds and saves an evening. When you're ready to reply, this workpaper helps you say it so it lands.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

05

## Hard things land better when they start soft.

How a hard talk begins often shapes how it ends. A complaint about one thing ("The bins weren't taken out") is easier to hear than a criticism of the person ("You never help"). A simple shape works for most hard things: what happened, how you feel, and what you'd like.

*For example:* A woman wants her elderly father to stop driving at night. Instead of "You're not safe anymore," she says: "You had two near-misses last month. I lie awake worrying. Could I drive us in the evenings?"

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"What happened was... I felt... Could we...?"

TRY THIS:

Write one fact, feeling and ask sentence about something small that has been bothering you. You don't have to send it yet.

## Say it so it lands

*A simple shape for most hard things.*

**What happened**
One specific fact, not a verdict.
*"The bins didn't go out on Tuesday."*

**How I feel**
Your feeling, in a word or two.
*"I felt let down, because I'd asked."*

**What I'd like**
A small, doable ask.
*"Could you set a reminder for next week?"*

✕ **Not: "You never help."**
*That's about the person, so it starts a defence.*

*This book's plain-language shape, a cousin of I-messages and Nonviolent Communication; research on such scripts is mixed, and tone matters most.*

FIGURE 4 Say it so it lands: what happened, how I feel, what I'd like. A complaint about an action can be heard; a criticism of the person starts a defence.

06

## Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill.

Even close, kind people misunderstand each other all the time. What keeps a relationship steady isn't never getting it wrong. It's noticing and fixing it: "That came out wrong," "I think I misread you," "Can we start again?" Small repairs, made often, build trust.

*For example:* At the supermarket, a stranger snaps "Excuse me!" when you block the aisle. You snap back. A second later you add, "Sorry, long day." They smile: "Me too." A tiny repair, and the moment is gone.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Can I try that again?" "I think I took that the wrong way. What did you mean?"

TRY THIS:
The next time something comes out wrong, repair it within a minute, out loud. Notice how small it can be.



SUGARFOOT
Sugarfoot's tip: a mix-up isn't the end of anything. Come back, sit close, and go through it step by step.

TOOL **After a talk went wrong: a step-by-step reset** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

07

## Messages lose their tone on the way.

A text or email carries the words but not your face, your voice or your timing. So the reader fills in the tone, and they fill it in with however *they* feel right now. A tired reader hears a tired, cross message. Short replies, missing greetings and late-night timing all get read as meaning something.

*For example*: A group chat for a school fundraiser. One parent replies "Fine." to a plan. Two others decide she is annoyed. She was typing one-handed while cooking.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Quick reply, not a cross one!" "This isn't urgent. Any time this week is fine."

TRY THIS:

Before you send your next tricky message, read it out loud in the grumpiest voice you can. If it sounds harsh, add a warm word or a time frame.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

**Chat analyzer: a whole conversation (once called the Conversation Reader)**

*Dana and Raj, coworkers on the same project*

### Chat analyzer: paste a conversation

#### 01 Paste the conversation

*Dana: Did the slides go to the client?*
*Raj: Not yet, still waiting on the numbers from finance*
*Dana: I needed them by 10. This always happens.*
*Raj: I can't make finance go faster.*
*Dana: Forget it. I'll do it myself.*

02 Which one is you?

*Dana (3 messages)* Raj (2 messages)

03 THE READ

**What happened**
Ends shut down. 5 messages: 3 from you, 2 from Raj. The words don't make it clear what it's mostly about, so the Reader won't guess. It starts calm. There's no one big turn, but some tension creeps in. By the end someone has pulled back. That isn't the same as calm: it can mean they're overwhelmed, or hurt.

**Your part · always / never**
I said "This always happens", and that isn't fair: it isn't every time. What I meant was: [one recent time, and how it felt].

### 04 Check your reply before you send it

Your reply
*Sorry, that last line wasn't fair. When the numbers weren't in by 10, I felt worried about the client. Could you ask finance for them by 9 next time? I'll chase them with you.*

THE CHECK

✓ Says what you need or how it landed · ✓ Makes one clear ask · ✓ No verdicts, always/never, dismissals, sarcasm, jabs, comparisons or shutting the door · ✓ Stays on one topic

Nothing in the wording is likely to add heat. Read it once more as if you were them, then send it when you're calm.

*A made-up example. Names and details are invented. The Reader looks at one side's part without blaming anyone.*

Fill in your own: Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator)

08

## Different styles aren't wrong styles.

Some people say exactly what they mean. Others hint and expect you to read between the lines. Some talk fast and overlap; others need a pause to think. Families, cultures and different kinds of minds all shape this. A clash between two styles is usually a translation problem, not a character flaw.

*For example*: An autistic employee answers "Is this report ready?" with "No, I need two more days." Her manager hears blunt. She was simply being clear and honest. Once they talk about it, he finds her clarity a relief.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm quite direct, so if I sound blunt, I'm not cross." "It helps me if you say exactly what you need."

> TRY THIS:
> Write one sentence about how you like to be spoken to, and share it with one person this week.

09

## Small talk has a job, and it can be short.

Small talk ("Cold today, isn't it?" "Busy weekend?") isn't really about the weather. Its job is to say "I see you, I'm friendly, we're okay." The anthropologist Bronisław Malinowski called this kind of talk "phatic communion" in 1923: talk whose main purpose is bonding, not information. Small moments like this matter more than people expect. Sandstrom and Dunn (2014) found that people who had a short, friendly exchange with a coffee-shop barista felt more belonging and a better mood than people who kept it purely efficient.

But small talk is hard work for many people, including many autistic people, shy or anxious people and people speaking a second language. The rules are unwritten, it can feel pointless, and it uses energy. A few ready-made lines, sometimes called social scripts, take the guesswork out. Keeping it short is allowed.

*For example*: A dad who dreads the school gate keeps three lines ready: "Morning! How's your week going?" then "Oh, nice," then "Right, I'd better get going. See you Friday." He no longer dreads it, and the other parents think he's lovely.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

To open: "Morning! How's your week been?" "How do you know Nico?" To keep it going: "Oh, how was that?" To close: "Lovely to see you. I'd better get on." "I'll let you get on. Have a good day." To opt out kindly: "I'm not great at chit-chat, but it's really nice to see you."

TRY THIS:

Write your own three lines: one to open, one follow-up question, one to close. Use them once this week. If you'd rather skip ahead to a real topic, that's fine too: "Can I ask you about something I'm actually curious about?"

THURSDAY, 9:02AM

*Ana's brother rings the moment he's off the bus. "Who's ill?" Ana laughs. "Nobody! I just wanted to ask if you're free on Saturday." He laughs too, a bit shakily. Next time, Ana texts: "No rush and nothing's wrong. Quick question about Saturday, call when you're free." Six more words. They save him a whole bus ride of worry.*

## In everyday life

### On your own: how you talk to yourself

Communication isn't only between people. You also send yourself messages all day: "Typical, I always mess this up," or "That was hard, and I handled it." The same ideas apply. Notice the tone, check whether the message is fair, and repair it when it's harsh.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "Is that what I actually mean, or just how it came out?" "What would I say to a friend who did this?"

> TRY THIS:
> Catch one harsh sentence you say to yourself today, and rewrite it in the way you'd speak to someone you like.

### With other people

The same few ideas show up everywhere people talk:

- **Partners:** "We never go out anymore" sounds like a complaint about evenings. Underneath, it may be "I miss you." Answering the second layer ("I miss you too, let's plan something") goes further than defending the calendar.
- **Parent and young child:** "Stop that!" tells a child what not to do, but not what to do instead. "Feet on the floor, please" is easier to follow, and easier to hear.
- **Coworkers:** In a meeting, silence is taken as agreement. Later, a quieter colleague says she never agreed. A round of "Anyone see it differently?" catches this.
- **Housemates:** A note on the fridge saying "PLEASE clean up" reads as shouting, even if it was written in a hurry. A face-to-face chat, or a kinder note, works better.

- **Grown-up child and parent:** "Are you eating properly?" is care in one generation's language and checking-up in another's. Both people can say what they mean and what they hear.
- **Strangers and services:** On a support call, saying "I'm frustrated, but not with you" often changes how the whole call goes.
- **Feedback at work:** Talk about the work, not the person, with one recent example and what good looks like. Then ask, "What's been getting in the way?" When you're the one receiving it, "Thanks. Can I think about it and come back tomorrow?" is a fine first answer. More, with a performance conversation (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-4-communication-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

- **"If they loved me, they'd just know."** Closeness makes us check *less*, not understand more. Saying it clearly is a kindness, not a failure.
- **"I said it clearly, so it's their fault they got it wrong."** Meaning is built by both people. You can be clear and still be misheard.
- **"Listening means agreeing."** You can fully understand someone and still see it differently. Understanding comes first; your view can come after.
- **"Being direct is rude."** Directness is a style. It can be warm and direct at the same time.
- **"Repairing means admitting I'm the bad one."** A repair just says "that didn't go how I wanted." Either person can make one.
- **"Small talk is fake."** It's a way of saying "we're okay with each other." You're allowed to keep it short, or to skip to a real topic.
- **"Texts are safer for hard things."** They feel safer to send, but they are easier to misread. For tender things, add warmth, or talk.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Maybe a friend keeps having the same argument with their partner, or your teenager feels nobody listens. You can't communicate for them, but you can help.

- **Listen first.** The most useful thing is often to be the person who really hears them, without fixing.

- **Help them separate the two layers.** "What was it about? And what did it seem to say about you two?"
- **Offer the simple shape.** What happened, how they feel, what they'd like. Let them find their own words.
- **Don't take sides on the other person's character.** You only hear one side, and they may make up next week.
- **Notice if it's more than a mix-up.** If they seem afraid of the other person, gently share Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Do you want me to just listen, or help you think about what to say?"

## When to get more help

Most mix-ups can be eased with the ideas here. Some situations need more.

- **When talking makes things worse every time,** a couples or family counsellor can slow conversations down and help both people be heard.
- **When you're afraid of how someone will react,** that isn't a communication problem. Clearer words are not the fix, and you don't have to keep trying. Not safe at home? lists free, private help, and signs to look out for may help you name what's happening.
- **When someone is always "misunderstanding" you** in ways that make you doubt your memory or your sense of what happened, talk with someone you trust outside the relationship.

- **When speaking or understanding is hard for you every day,** because of anxiety, a hearing or language difference, or how your mind works, a doctor, speech and language therapist or counsellor may help. Needing support is not a failing.
- **If you're overwhelmed right now,** start with Upset right now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now).

## Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

PRACTICE:
try one tool this week, with one real conversation.

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- Chat analyzer: calm replies after a fight.
- Communication style quiz (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz): a playful look at your own style.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Effective communication (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication): the site's complete, plain guide, from listening and timing to hard talks, repair and each kind of relationship.
- Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins): how to hold a hard conversation kindly.
- In the book: Chapter I: Why we get out of tune (page 7) looks at the same ideas at home.

## More for your situation

- At work: messages and meetings (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)

- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) and for parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents)
- Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting)
- Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance)
- Two faiths or cultures, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths)
- Neurodivergent relationships: communication (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

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WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Meaning is made between two people.** What you say and what they hear can be different, and nobody has to be wrong.
- ✓ **Every message says two things:** the words, and what they seem to say about the two of you.
- ✓ **Check, don't guess.** A short question saves a long misunderstanding.
- ✓ **Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill.** And small talk is allowed to be short.

## THIS CONNECTS TO

**Chapter 1 · Why we get out of tune**
*Pace, tone and getting back in tune*
page 7

**Book 4 · Two kinds of fair**
*Letting a comment land*
Share the Load

**Book 2 · Healing after hurt**
*Repair after it goes wrong*
Heal and Steady

**Book 1 · Your wiring, weather and words**
*How you like to be spoken to*
Know Yourself Kindly

## PUT IT TO USE



**Chat analyzer**
Calm replies after a fight
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator



**Communication style quiz**
A playful look at your own style
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz



**Go deeper (free online)** The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-4-communication-in-depth

# 3

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 3 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 3

# How we see each other: perception, bias, and the stories we tell

*Why two people can watch the same moment and come away with two different stories, and how to see others, and yourself, a little more fairly.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Seeing is a best guess
2. You see what you're looking for
3. We fill the gaps with stories
4. We judge ourselves by our reasons, and others by their actions
5. Quick shortcuts can lead us astray
6. Everyone feels like the one who sees clearly
7. "Us" and "them" changes what we see
8. Ask, don't guess
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation


IN SHORT:

- **Seeing is a best guess.** Your brain fills in a lot of what you think you see and hear.
- **We fill gaps with stories,** and the story often feels like a fact.
- **We judge ourselves by our reasons and others by their actions.** That gap causes a lot of hurt.

- **Ask, don't guess.** Asking is kinder and more accurate than reading minds.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **Who did what** (the Preface to Part Two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface)) works because everyone sees their own effort more clearly than other people's. Two honest guesses of "I do about 60%" can add up to more than 100%. Writing it down replaces two best guesses with one shared page. Big idea: *see the whole load.*
- **See it from their side (the Perspective Shifter)** (Part Two, Chapter III (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3)) slows down a habit everyone has: judging ourselves by our reasons and other people by their actions.
- **The Chat analyzer (also called the Signal Translator)** follows this chapter's last idea: ask, don't guess.

WEDNESDAY, 12:15PM

*You wave at a coworker across the canteen. She looks straight through you and walks off. All afternoon you wonder what you did. At four, she messages: "Sorry I didn't stop, I'd just had a call about my dad." She never saw you. The whole story was yours.*

The first two chapters of Part Three looked inside: feelings, and the stress that shapes them. This chapter looks outward, at how we see other people. It explains why misunderstandings are so common, even between kind and clever people, and what helps.

01

## Seeing is a best guess.

Your eyes and ears take in far less than you think. Your brain fills in the rest from what it expects. Most of the time this works well and fast. But it means what you see is partly what you expected to see. Two people can watch the same moment and honestly see different things.

*For example*: Two parents watch their son at a football match. One sees him "giving up." The other sees him "being careful with a sore ankle." Same boy. Different guesses.

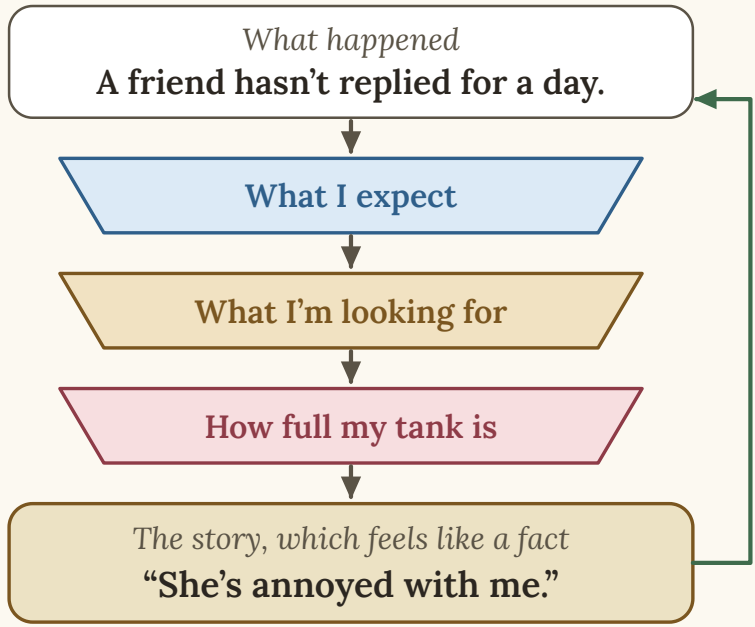
> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "This is what I see. It might not be all there is." "What else could this be?"

TRY THIS:

Next time you're sure what someone meant by a look, think of two other things it could have meant.

## Seeing is a best guess

*What happened passes through filters before it becomes "what I saw".*




**Ask, don't guess.**
"*Is everything okay?*"
Her phone broke.

*Illustration. The brain fills gaps from what it expects ("predictive processing", an influential idea, still debated).*

FIGURE 5 Seeing is a best guess. The story that comes out feels like a fact; asking is kinder and more accurate than reading minds.

02

### You see what you're looking for.

Attention is like a torch in a dark room. What it lights up, you see. What it doesn't, you can miss, even if it's right in front of you. If you're looking for proof that someone doesn't care, you'll notice every missed call and none of the little kindnesses.

*For example*: A woman decides her new manager "doesn't like her." For a month she notices every short email. She misses that he gave her the best project.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"What might I be missing?" "If I were looking for the opposite, what would I see?"

TRY THIS:

For one week, write down one kind thing a person you're struggling with does each day. Just notice.

03

### We fill the gaps with stories.

When we don't know why someone did something, the mind makes up a reason, fast. A late reply becomes "they're angry." A closed door becomes "they don't want me." The story arrives feeling like a fact. Memory works this way too: each time we remember something, we rebuild it a little, so two people can honestly remember the same evening differently.

*For example*: A friend doesn't reply for two days. You decide she's fed up with you. She was on a camping trip with no signal.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"The story I'm telling myself is that you're upset with me. Is that right?"

TRY THIS:

When you feel hurt by something someone did, write down the story you're telling yourself. Then write one other possible story.

04

## We judge ourselves by our reasons, and others by their actions.

When you are late, you know why: the traffic, the phone call, the child who lost a shoe. When someone else is late, you only see that they're late, and it's easy to think "they're careless." We all tend to blame other people's character for things that are really about their situation.

*For example:* A driver cuts in front of you, and you think "what an idiot." Next week, rushing to the hospital, you cut someone up yourself, and you know you're not an idiot.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"What might be going on for them that I can't see?" "If I did this, what would my reason be?"

TRY THIS:

When someone annoys you today, think of one situation that would explain it without making them a bad person.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

We know our own reasons and only see other people's actions. Writing out their side, in their words, is a fair way to even that up.

TOOL **After a talk went wrong: a step-by-step reset** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

05

## Quick shortcuts can lead us astray.

The brain uses shortcuts to save time. Many are useful. Some lead to unfair judgements: a first impression that colours everything after it, a bad moment that outweighs ten good ones, or a quick guess about someone based on their age, accent, looks or group. Having these shortcuts doesn't make you a bad person. Not noticing them can make you an unfair one.

*For example*: A housemate decides on day one that the new tenant is "messy" because of one box in the hall. Every bit of mess after that is "proof," while her own mess goes unseen.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "Am I looking for proof of what I already think?" "Would I judge this the same if someone I like did it?"

TRY THIS:
Pick one person you've made your mind up about. Look for one thing that doesn't fit your view of them.

06

## Everyone feels like the one who sees clearly.

Most of us feel we see things as they really are, and that anyone who disagrees must be missing something, biased or not thinking straight. The other person feels exactly the same about you. Neither of you can see your own lens, only theirs.

*For example*: Two adult siblings argue about how their parents raised them. Each says, "I'm just being realistic." Both are telling the truth about what they lived through.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think we're both seeing this from where we stand. Can you tell me how it looks from yours?"

TRY THIS:

In your next disagreement, explain the other person's view back to them until they say, "Yes, that's it." Then give yours.

07

## "Us" and "them" changes what we see.

People quickly split into groups, even over tiny things. We tend to see our own group as varied and full of individuals, and other groups as "all the same." We give our own side the benefit of the doubt. Spending real time with people from the other group, as equals, is one of the best ways to soften this.

*For example*: At work, the night shift calls the day shift "lazy," and the day shift calls the night shift "sloppy." After a joint team day, they start saying names instead of "them."

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Would I say this about one of 'us'?" "Who in that group do I actually know?"

TRY THIS:

Have one real conversation this month with someone from a group you tend to see as "other." Ask about their day, not their views.

08

## Ask, don't guess.

Imagining yourself in someone's shoes is a kind start. But research suggests it doesn't make us much more accurate about what they think. Asking does. A simple, curious question beats the cleverest guess. "What was that like for you?" is a better tool than "I know exactly how you feel."

*For example:* A grandmother thinks her teenage grandson hates visiting because he's on his phone. She asks. He's messaging a friend who is having a hard time, and he likes being at her house because it's calm.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Can I check what you meant?" "What was going on for you?" "I might have this wrong. How did it look from your side?"

TRY THIS:

Once today, swap a guess for a question.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

**Chat analyzer (also called the Signal Translator)**

*Zoe, texting her oldest friend, who moved abroad*

### Chat analyzer

Mode

*I'm about to send this* Someone sent me this

Type your sentence

*You always cancel on me last minute. Can we pick a time for a call on Sunday?*

Relationship

*Friends*

Channel

*Text / chat*

THE READ

**How it may land for most listeners**
Some words may hurt. How it may sound: sharp in places.

**What stands out**
The word “always” (words like “always” and “never” leave no room for the times it went fine).

**A clearer way to say it**
Lately it’s felt like you cancel on me last minute. Can we pick a time for a call on Sunday?

**What changed, and why**
always → lately it’s felt like. “Always” and “never” erase every exception, so the listener argues the exception.

*A made-up example. Names and details are invented. The ask stayed; only the word that would start an argument changed.*

Fill in your own: Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator)

THURSDAY, 12:20PM

*You see your coworker in the canteen again. This time you go over: “How’s your dad?” She tells you. You sit together. Yesterday’s story about what you did wrong is gone. It was only ever a guess.*

## In everyday life

- **On your own:** We tell stories about ourselves too. “I always mess things up” is a story built from a few bright memories. Look for the ones it leaves out. See Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself).

- **With a partner:** After years together, we stop checking and start assuming. “I know what you meant” is the most dangerous sentence in a long relationship.
- **With friends:** A friend going quiet is rarely about you. Ask before you decide. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).
- **Parents and children:** Children are often labelled early: “the difficult one,” “the easy one.” Labels can become lenses that only see what fits. See For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents).
- **At work:** Short emails, flat faces and different working styles are easy to misread. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).
- **In your community:** People from other backgrounds, faiths or generations are easiest to see as “all the same.” See Two faiths, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths).
- **With ADHD:** Attention is pulled by what is new or urgent, and can lock on hard. Someone may truly not have seen or heard. Not seeing isn’t the same as not caring. Get attention first, and put requests in writing. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-3-seeing-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

- **"I just see things as they are."** Everyone sees through a lens. Knowing that is where fairness starts.
- **"Being biased means being a bad person."** Everyone uses mental shortcuts. What matters is noticing them and checking.
- **"If I imagine their side hard enough, I'll understand."** Imagining is a start. Asking is usually more accurate.
- **"My memory is a recording."** Memory is rebuilt each time. Two honest people can remember the same event differently.
- **"Giving the benefit of the doubt means ignoring what happened."** No. It means checking the story before deciding. If something hurtful keeps happening, that matters.
- **"Their face or tone told me what they meant."** Faces and tones vary a lot between people and cultures, and between neurotypes. They are clues, not proof.

## If you want to help someone else with this

- **Don't argue with their story first.** Make sense of how they feel, then gently ask, "Is there any other way to see it?"
- **Offer information, not verdicts.** "I know she had a hard week" helps more than "You're being unfair to her."
- **Model asking.** Let people see you check your own guesses out loud: "I assumed he was annoyed. I'll ask."
- **Be careful with labels.** Labels for children, coworkers or family members stick, and then shape what everyone sees.

- **Believe people about their own experience.** Seeing other angles never means telling someone their experience didn't happen.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "That sounds really hurtful. Do you know what was going on for them?" "It might be worth asking. Want to plan what to say?"

## When to get more help

Seeing other people's side is a strength. It should never mean doubting yourself when you know something is wrong. If someone often tells you that what you saw, heard or remember didn't happen, that you're "too sensitive" or "imagining it," and you find yourself unsure of your own mind, take that seriously. It can be part of controlling behaviour. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) and Not safe at home? can help, privately.

It may also help to talk to a counsellor or other trained professional if you notice you often feel others are against you, find it hard to trust anyone, or keep getting stuck in the same painful stories about yourself. Those patterns are common, understandable and often change with support.

This chapter is general education, not diagnosis or therapy.

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- See it from their side (spreadloveandacceptance.com/perspective-shifter): a free perspective-taking tool.

- Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator): how a sentence might land before you say it.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently): how different minds hear the same words.
- Philosophy stories on seeing the other person (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth): the cave, the elephant, the fish and the empty boat.
- The library: the fundamental attribution error (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking), confirmation bias, negativity bias, naive realism, mind-reading and how memory is rebuilt.

## More for your situation

- Back: Stress and the nervous system (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-2-stress) · Next: How communication works (page 25)
- Part One, Then: where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then)
- Part Two, Chapter III: full tanks and different angles
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts), Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) and For grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children)
- Communication between different minds (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) and For parents
- The whole book (spreadloveandacceptance.com/contents) · Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Seeing is a best guess.** Your brain fills in a lot of what you think you see and hear.
- ✓ **We fill gaps with stories,** and the story often feels like a fact.
- ✓ **We judge ourselves by our reasons and others by their actions.** That gap causes a lot of hurt.
- ✓ **Ask, don't guess.** Asking is kinder and more accurate than reading minds.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Book 1 · Where your lens came from**
*Where your lens came from*
Know Yourself Kindly

**Book 4 · The work nobody sees**
*Why the other person doesn't see the work*
Share the Load

**Book 4 · Full tanks and different angles**
*Seven angles on the same moment*
Share the Load

**Chapter 6 · Groups, influence and culture**
*Us and them, and the stories groups tell*
page 97

PUT IT TO USE

**See it from their side**
A free perspective-taking tool
spreadloveandacceptance.com/perspective-shifter

**Chat analyzer**
How a sentence might land before you say it
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

**Go deeper (free online)** The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-3-seeing-in-depth

# 4

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 4 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 5

# Attachment, trust and belonging

*Why we need each other, how the bonds we had early on shape what we expect today, and how trust and belonging are built, lost and rebuilt, one small moment at a time.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Belonging is a basic need
2. Early bonds teach us what to expect
3. Patterns, not boxes
4. Trust is built in small moments
5. Feeling safe with someone calms the body
6. Fitting in isn't the same as belonging
7. When trust breaks, rebuilding takes time
8. You can start building connection from wherever you are
9. If you're a teenager
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Reading on this site
15. More for your situation


IN SHORT:

- **Belonging is a basic need.** Feeling lonely or left out is a signal, like hunger, not a flaw.
- **Early bonds set expectations, not a sentence.** What we learned about being cared for can soften and change.
- **Trust grows in small moments.** Doing what you said, again and again, matters more than big gestures.
- **You can start small.** One friendly exchange, one kept promise, one kind word to yourself.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **One owner per job** (Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) works because trust is built from small promises kept. A named owner turns a vague hope ("someone will do it") into a promise others can rely on. Big idea: *fix the setup, not the person.*
- **The monthly look-back** (Part Two, Chapter V (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5)) is "not a review of either person". Feeling safe with someone is what lets people say what went wrong without bracing for blame.

SUNDAY, 9:30PM

*Kai sent a long message to a friend at lunchtime. It's been read, but there's no reply. By evening, Kai has gone from "she's busy" to "she's annoyed with me" to "nobody really likes me." The friend, meanwhile, is at her nephew's birthday, phone in a coat pocket. One silence, two very different nights.*

01

## Belonging is a basic need.

People need to feel connected, the way we need food and sleep. When we feel left out, it can hurt in a way that feels almost physical (Naomi Eisenberger and colleagues, 2003). That isn't weakness. It's a signal, like hunger, telling us to reach for connection.

*For example*: Rhea moves to a new city for work. She's busy and doing well, but by the third month she feels flat and teary on

Sundays. Nothing is wrong with her. She's lonely, and loneliness is a real need asking to be met.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
"Feeling lonely doesn't mean I'm unlikeable. It means I need connection, like anyone."

TRY THIS:
This week, reach out to one person, even with a short "thinking of you" message.

02

## Early bonds teach us what to expect.

As children, we learn from the people who cared for us whether others will come when we need them. If help usually came, we tend to expect it. If it came sometimes, or rarely, we may learn to cling harder or to stop asking. These lessons are a starting point, not a life sentence. This is the idea of attachment, first described by John Bowlby (1969) and studied by Mary Ainsworth and colleagues (1978).

*For example:* A toddler at the park runs off to explore, then runs back to check his grandmother is still on the bench, then runs off again. She is his safe base. Knowing she's there makes him brave enough to explore.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
(to a child) "I'm right here. Go and look, and come back whenever you want."

TRY THIS:
Think of one person who was a safe base for you, at any age. What did they do that helped?

03

## Patterns, not boxes.

As adults, some of us worry a lot about being left, and reach out more when we feel unsure. Some of us pull back when things get close, and need more space. Many of us feel mostly secure, and most of us mix all three.

These are patterns that can soften and change, especially in steady, kind relationships. Cindy Hazan and Phillip Shaver (1987) first described them in adults, and later work, such as R. Chris Fraley and colleagues (2015), suggests they are sliding scales, not boxes.

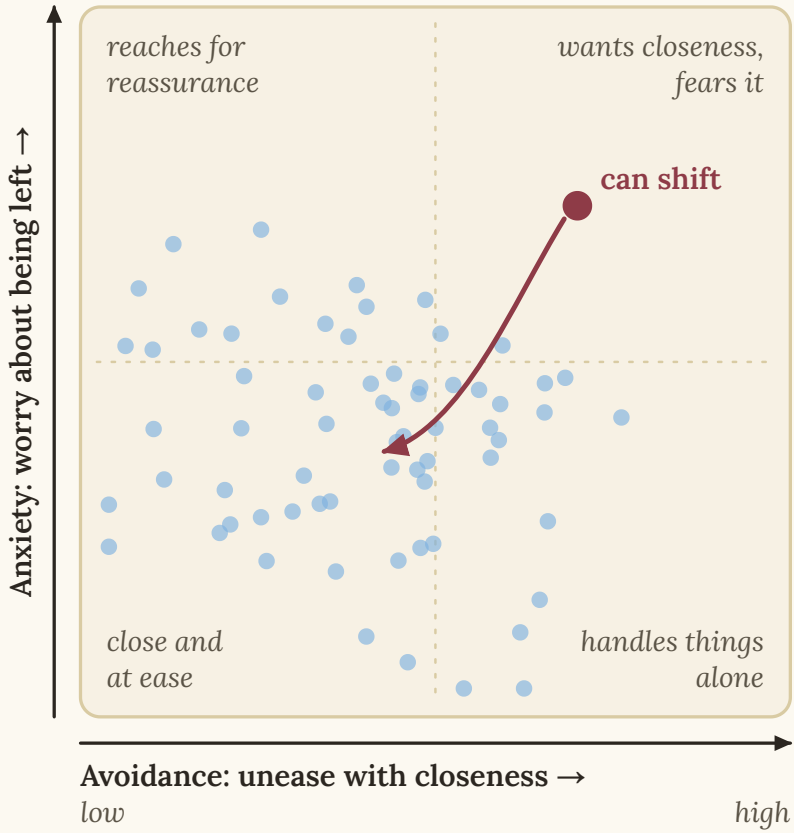
*For example*: When things feel tense, Ronan wants to talk it through right now. His wife Clara needs to go quiet first. He reads her quiet as "she's leaving." She reads his questions as pressure. Once they see the pattern, they agree: Clara says "I need an hour, and I'm coming back," and Ronan waits.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm not going anywhere. I just need some quiet. Let's talk at eight."

TRY THIS:
Notice what you do when you feel unsure of someone: reach out more, or pull back? No judgement, just notice.

## Patterns, not boxes

*Two scales. Everyone sits somewhere, and can move.*




*After Brennan, Clark and Shaver (1998) and Fraley and colleagues (2015): adult attachment is best measured as two scales, not types. Dots are illustrative, not data.*

FIGURE 6 Attachment as two scales, not four boxes: worry about being left, and unease with closeness. Everyone sits somewhere, and can move. Dots are illustrative.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

**Our pause plan**
*Imani and Kwame, married ten years*

## Our pause plan

Fill this in together on a calm day, or fill it in yourself and send it to your partner to change.

Our pause word or sentence
*"Pause. I'll be back at …", with a hand on the heart*

Shortest break, so our bodies can settle
*30 minutes*

Whoever pauses names a clock time to come back, no later than
*the same evening*

If one of us can't come back on time
*Send one text with a new time. No silence.*

The first sentence when we come back
*"I'm back. You first: what do you most want me to hear?"*

YOUR PLAN, READY TO SEND

Our pause plan

Pause word: “Pause. I’ll be back at …”, with a hand on the heart

Shortest break: 30 minutes

Return time: whoever pauses names a clock time, no later than the same evening

If one of us can’t come back on time: Send one text with a new time. No silence.

When we come back, we start with: “I’m back. You first: what do you most want me to hear?”

*A made-up example. Names and details are invented. For relationships where everyone feels safe.*

Fill in your own: Our pause plan (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw)

04

## Trust is built in small moments.

Trust doesn’t usually come from big gestures. It grows from small, ordinary things done again and again: doing what you said, turning towards someone when they reach out, being the same person on a hard day as on a good one.

*For example:* A new team member says she’ll send the figures by Thursday, and she does. The next week, she flags early that something will be late. By the third month, her manager trusts her completely, not because of one big moment, but dozens of small ones.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I said I'd do it by Friday. I'm running late, so here's where it's at."

TRY THIS:

Keep one small promise today, and notice how it feels to be someone who does what they said.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Trust grows in small moments that repeat. This workpaper helps you notice the little rituals you already have, and keep them going.

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · free to print

· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15

05

## Feeling safe with someone calms the body.

Being with someone we trust can settle our nervous system. In one study, holding a trusted partner's hand calmed the brain's response to threat (James Coan and colleagues, 2006). A calm voice, a hand to hold, or just someone nearby can make a hard moment easier to bear. This works both ways: we can be that safe presence for others too, often without saying much.

*For example*: After a panic attack, Kieran's friend doesn't try to fix anything. He sits next to him on the step and says, "Take your time. I'm here." Kieran's breathing slows.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"You don't have to talk. I'll just sit with you." "What would help right now: company, quiet, or both?"

TRY THIS:

Notice who helps you feel calmer. Tell them, simply: “I always feel better after seeing you.”

06

## Fitting in isn’t the same as belonging.

Fitting in means changing yourself to be accepted. Belonging means being accepted as you are. Groups like teams, families, clubs and communities can offer both. Being left out of a group hurts, even when the group doesn’t matter much to us. Real belonging grows where people feel safe to be themselves and to speak up.

*For example*: At a new job, Ola laughs at jokes she doesn’t find funny and hides that she doesn’t drink. She’s fitting in, and she’s exhausted. At a book club, she says what she really thinks and people ask her to say more. That’s belonging.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

(in a group) “I see it a bit differently. Is it okay if I say why?”
“Has everyone had a chance to say something?”

TRY THIS:

Think of one place where you can be fully yourself. How could you spend a little more time there?

07

## When trust breaks, rebuilding takes time.

When someone lets us down badly, trust doesn’t come back with one apology. It returns slowly, as words are matched by actions over time. The person who broke trust can own what happened and be patient. The person who was hurt can decide, at their own pace, whether and how much to trust again.

*For example*: Two adult sisters fall out after one shares a private story at a family dinner. The apology is a start. What rebuilds trust is the months afterwards, when the story never comes up again and the sister checks before sharing anything.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I know sorry isn't enough. I'll show you, and you can take whatever time you need."

TRY THIS:

If you've broken someone's trust, name one specific thing you'll do differently, and do it.

08

### You can start building connection from wherever you are.

If you feel alone right now, big friendships can feel out of reach. But belonging starts small: a chat with a neighbour, a regular class, an online group about something you love, a kind word to yourself. Even small, light contact with people we barely know can lift our mood (Gillian Sandstrom and Elizabeth Dunn, 2014).

*For example*: After his divorce, Martin starts saying more than "thanks" to the man at the coffee stall. A few weeks later they talk football every morning. It isn't a deep friendship, but it makes Mondays easier, and it reminds him he can still connect.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm new around here. Is there anything you'd recommend?" "I loved what you said in the group. Would you like to get a coffee sometime?"

TRY THIS:

Have one small, friendly exchange with someone you don't know well this week.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: one small hello is a great start! Want an idea? There's a tool that picks one for you.

TOOL **Get one small bonding idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

MONDAY, 8:10AM

*Kai's phone buzzes. "Sorry! Phone was in my coat all day at my nephew's party. Loved your message. Coffee Thursday?" Kai notices how far last night's story had run: from "she's busy" all the way to "nobody likes me." Next time a reply is slow, Kai decides to send a light "No rush, just thinking of you," and let the silence be just a silence.*

## If you're a teenager

A *made-up example.* Ezra, 16, sees a photo of his three closest friends at the cinema, and finds out there's a group chat he isn't in. It hurts like a punch. Being left out really does register a bit like pain. Instead of posting something sharp, he messages one friend: "Bit gutted not to be asked. Did I do something?" It turns out they thought he'd be at football. One friendship really is drifting, though, and that's allowed to hurt too.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Bit gutted not to be asked. Did something happen?" "I'd like to come next time, even if I can't always make it." "I miss how we used to be. Are we okay?"

## In everyday life

- **Partners:** One partner texts a lot when apart; the other forgets. Agreeing on one goodnight message keeps both feeling connected.
- **Parents and children:** A child who acts up at pick-up may simply be releasing a long day with the safest person they know.
- **Friends:** A friend who always cancels may be overwhelmed, not uncaring. Asking "Is it easier if we do something short?" keeps the door open.
- **Coworkers:** A team where mistakes can be admitted without blame builds trust faster than one where everyone hides them.
- **Housemates:** A weekly shared meal, even a simple one, can turn people who share a kitchen into people who look out for each other.
- **Community:** A neighbour who waves every morning is a small, real part of feeling at home.

### On your own: belonging with yourself

Belonging isn't only about other people. It also includes how you treat yourself. If you're kind to yourself on a bad day, you carry a little safe base wherever you go. People who learn to comfort themselves often find it easier to let others in, too, because they're less afraid of being let down.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"I'm allowed to need people." "Today was lonely. That's hard, and it won't always be like this."

More for people on their own: On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

## Common mix-ups

- **"Needing people means I'm needy."** Needing connection is human. Everyone has this need, even those who hide it well.
- **"My attachment style is fixed for life."** Patterns can change, especially through steady, kind relationships and reflection.
- **"An 'anxious' or 'avoidant' label explains everything."** Labels can help you notice patterns, but people are more than a type. Use them for curiosity, not judgement.
- **"Jealousy and checking up show how much they love me."** Reaching for reassurance is human, and so is asking for something out of care for the relationship. Controlling who someone sees, or checking their phone without agreement, is not love and is not an attachment style. See signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety).
- **"If I forgive, I have to trust again straight away."** Forgiving and trusting are different. Trust can return slowly, or not at all, and that's your call.
- **"Belonging means everyone likes me."** Belonging usually means a few people who know you as you are. That's enough.

## If you want to help someone else with this

- **Be a steady presence.** Reliability matters more than big gestures. Turn up when you said you would.
- **Take loneliness seriously.** If someone says they feel alone, don't rush to "But you have so many friends!" Listen first.
- **Invite, and keep inviting.** People who feel left out may say no a few times. A warm, no-pressure invitation still matters.
- **Make room in groups.** Notice who is on the edge, and ask their view.
- **Don't diagnose.** Avoid telling someone they're "so avoidant" or "so clingy." Ask what would help instead.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm here, and I'm not going anywhere." "We're having a few people over on Friday. No pressure, but I'd love you to come."

## When to get more help

- **If loneliness has lasted a long time,** or comes with low mood, hopelessness or thoughts of not wanting to be here, please talk to a doctor or a mental health service. If you are in danger right now, call your local emergency number or see Upset right now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now).
- **If fear of being left, or of getting close, keeps hurting your relationships,** a counsellor or therapist can help you understand where it comes from and how to change it.
- **If someone uses your need for them against you,** by cutting you off from friends, checking where you are, or threatening to leave to get their way, that is not about attachment. Not safe at home? lists free, private help.

- **If trust was broken in a way that frightened you,** you don't owe anyone a second chance. Your safety comes first.

## Reading on the website

PRACTICE:

pick one small way to turn towards someone this week.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Bonding: how closeness grows (spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding): what research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family, coworkers and you.
- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends): when a friendship drifts, and how to reach out.
- The languages of connection (spreadloveandacceptance.com/languages-of-connection): the different ways people show care.
- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency): why good things fade, and how to keep them alive.

## More for your situation

- On my own after a breakup
- Friends
- Parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) and foster, adoptive and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)
- Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance)
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)

- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

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WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Belonging is a basic need.** Feeling lonely or left out is a signal, like hunger, not a flaw.
- ✓ **Early bonds set expectations, not a sentence.** What we learned about being cared for can soften and change.
- ✓ **Trust grows in small moments.** Doing what you said, again and again, matters more than big gestures.
- ✓ **You can start small.** One friendly exchange, one kept promise, one kind word to yourself.

## THIS CONNECTS TO

**Book 1 · Where your lens came from**
*Early trust and the rules from home*
Know Yourself Kindly

**Chapter 5 · Closeness and love**
*Being known, at every age*
page 79

**Chapter 6 · Groups, influence and culture**
*Belonging to groups, and their pull*
page 97

**Book 2 · Loss, grief and big life changes**
*When a bond is lost*
Heal and Steady

## PUT IT TO USE

**Bonding: how closeness grows**
What research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family, coworkers and you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

**Friends**
When a friendship drifts, and how to reach out
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

**Go deeper (free online)** The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-5-belonging-in-depth

# 5

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 5 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 15

# Closeness and love: being known, at every age

*How closeness grows, what it means to feel truly known, how love changes over the years, and how it looks in every kind of relationship, at every age, including for people on their own.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Love comes in many forms
2. Closeness grows from being known
3. Closeness is built a step at a time
4. Feeling understood matters most
5. Old maps show up in love
6. Love changes over time
7. Love at every age
8. Love is something you do
9. If you're a teenager
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Reading on this site
15. More for your situation


IN SHORT:

- **Love comes in many forms.** Friends, family, partners, chosen family and the love you give yourself are all real love.
- **Closeness grows from being known.** You share something real, and the other person responds with understanding and care.
- **Love changes over time.** Early excitement often settles, and long love can stay warm, close and even exciting.

- **Love is something you do,** in small ways, every day. It never includes fear or control.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **The 90-second daily check-in** (Part Two, Chapter I (page 7)) has an appreciation line, because closeness grows from small, frequent moments of being seen and known.
- **Who did what** (the Preface to Part Two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface)) matters for love too: work one person never sees slowly wears closeness down. Big idea: *see the whole load.*

FRIDAY, 10:30PM

*You and Charlie have shared a home for eleven years. Tonight you're both on the sofa, both on your phones. You realise you can't remember the last time you talked about anything except bills, the boiler and whose turn it is to cook. You love Charlie. You just feel, oddly, a little alone in the same room.*

This chapter isn't only about romance. It's about closeness in all its forms: what helps people feel near to each other, why it can fade, and how it can grow again. It builds on Chapter 5 (page 61), on attachment and trust.

01

## Love comes in many forms.

The ancient Greeks had several words for love: for friends, for family, for romantic partners and for strangers. Today people love in many ways too: lifelong friendships, partners of any gender,

people with more than one partner, chosen family, people who are asexual or aromantic and build deep closeness without romance or sex, and people on their own who pour love into friends, family, pets, work and community. No form is the "real" one. A life can be full of love without a partner in it.

*For example*: A woman in her fifties who has never wanted a partner says her closest relationship is with her best friend of thirty years. They've been through two house moves, one cancer scare and countless Sunday phone calls. "That's my great love story," she says.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "Who are the people I love, in all the forms it takes?" "The love I have counts, even if it doesn't look like a film."

> TRY THIS:
> Write down three people (or more) you love, of any kind. Next to each, write one way you show it.

02

### Closeness grows from being known.

Intimacy isn't only about touch or romance. At its heart is being known. Psychologists Reis and Shaver described it as a back-and-forth: one person shares something real about themselves, and the other responds in a way that leaves them feeling understood, accepted and cared for. In a diary study by Laurenceau, Barrett and Pietromonaco (1998), feeling that the other person really responded was a big part of what made everyday conversations feel intimate.

*For example*: Two brothers who talk mainly about football are driving to their dad's care home. One says, "I find these visits really

hard." The other says, "Me too. I always feel guilty on the way home." They've never felt closer.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Can I tell you something I haven't said out loud before?"
"Thank you for telling me. That makes sense."

TRY THIS:

Share one small, true thing with someone you care about: a worry, a hope, or something that made you happy this week. Then notice how they respond.

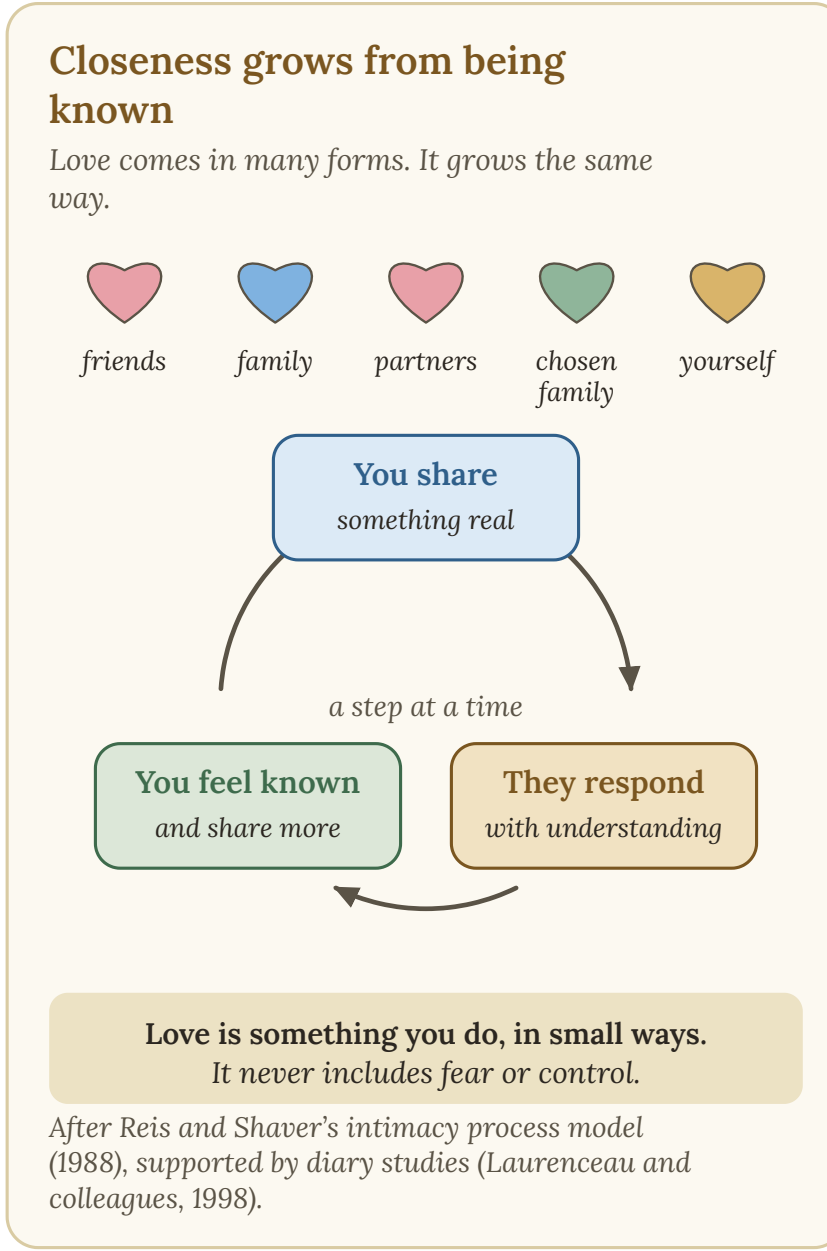



FIGURE 7 Closeness grows from being known: you share something real, the other person responds with understanding, and you share a little more.

03

## Closeness is built a step at a time.

People usually get close by sharing a little more, and a little more, when it feels safe. In a well-known study by Aron and colleagues (1997), pairs of strangers who took turns asking gradually more personal questions (now known as the "36 questions") felt closer after 45 minutes than pairs who made small talk. The same idea works in friendships and long relationships: closeness grows when both people take small, matched steps.

*For example*: Two new neighbours start with weather and parking. Over a few months, it becomes "How's your mum doing?" and later, "Can I tell you what's really been going on?" Neither rushed it.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "What's something you're looking forward to?" "What's been on your mind lately?" "What was the best part of your week?"

TRY THIS:

Ask someone one question a little deeper than usual. If they answer, share something of your own back.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Closeness grows when you know what feels like care to the other person, not just to you. A care card is a gentle way to find out.

TOOL **What feels like care to me: a care card** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

04

## Feeling understood matters most.

What makes someone feel loved is often less about grand gestures and more about feeling understood. Researchers call this *responsiveness*: noticing, understanding and caring about what matters to the other person. It shows in small moments, like how

you react to good news. Gable and colleagues (2004) found that people whose partners usually met their good news with real interest and warmth felt closer and more satisfied together.

*For example:* A teenager says, "I got picked for the band!" Her grandad stops what he's doing, smiles, and asks, "What instrument? When's the first concert?" She talks for twenty minutes.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Tell me everything!" "That sounds like it really mattered to you." "What was that like?"

> TRY THIS:
> The next time someone shares good news, put your phone down and ask two follow-up questions.

05

### Old maps show up in love.

The patterns from Chapter 5 (page 61) often come out most strongly with the people we love most. Hazan and Shaver (1987) suggested that adult love uses the same attachment system as childhood bonds. When closeness feels shaky, some people reach harder for reassurance; others pull back to feel safe. Neither is bad. Both are ways of protecting something precious.

*For example:* When his partner goes quiet, Leo texts five times in an hour. His partner, who goes quiet to calm down, feels crowded. They agree: "I need an hour, and I'll message you at eight." Leo can wait for a known time.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm feeling unsure of us right now. Can you tell me we're okay?" "I need some space, and I'm coming back. Let's talk at eight."

TRY THIS:

Notice what you do when closeness feels shaky: reach out, pull back, or both. Tell someone you trust what helps you feel safe again.

06

### Love changes over time.

Early love is often intense, with racing thoughts and a lot of longing. Over years, it usually settles into something calmer and deeper. That isn't failure. A review by Acevedo and Aron (2009) found that some people in long relationships still report strong romantic love, without the anxious, obsessive edge of early love, and that this was linked to being happier together.

In experiments by Aron and colleagues (2000), couples who tried a new, mildly challenging activity together felt better about their relationship afterwards than couples given a dull task.

*For example*: After twenty-five years, a couple take a pottery class. They're both terrible at it and laugh all evening. On the way home, one says, "I feel like we're on a date."

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Calm isn't the same as cold." "What could we try that's new for both of us?"

TRY THIS:

Plan one small new thing with someone you love: a new walk, a new recipe, a new place. New for both of you matters more than big.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: little rituals, like a Sunday walk or a goodnight text, keep love warm through the years. Look after the ones you have.

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15

07

## Love at every age.

Love looks different across a life. Teenagers' first loves can be huge and real. Adults juggle love with work, children and caring for parents. Many older people choose to spend their time with fewer, closer people. Carstensen and colleagues (1999) linked this to feeling that time is more limited, which makes the most meaningful relationships matter more. People find new love at seventy and eighty. People lose great loves and carry them always. All of it counts.

*For example*: A widower of seventy-eight meets a woman at his walking group. His children are surprised. He says, "I loved your mother for fifty years. I still do. And I'm allowed to be happy now."

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"It's never too late to be close to someone." "Missing someone is a form of love too."

TRY THIS:

Reach out to someone from another generation this week: an older relative, a younger neighbour or a colleague. Ask them about love in their life, if it feels right.

08

### Love is something you do.

Feelings of love come and go. The actions of love can be steady: turning towards someone when they speak, keeping small promises, saying thank you, saying sorry, making room for who they are. Physical closeness, like a hug or holding hands, matters a lot to some people and less to others, and sex is part of closeness for some relationships and not others. What matters is that both people feel comfortable and free to say yes or no. Love never includes fear, threats or control.

*For example*: A friend notices her friend has been quiet since his divorce. She doesn't say "I love you," but every Thursday she texts, "Walk?" and turns up. That is love too.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"What makes you feel most loved by me?" "Is this okay for you?" "I noticed you've been quiet. I'm here."

TRY THIS:

Ask someone you love, "What's one small thing that makes you feel cared for?" Then do it this week.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

**Our time-together deal**

*Jamal and Tess, a couple; Jamal games most evenings*

### Our time-together deal

Your name
*Jamal*

Their name
*Tess*

Game nights (or long phone time)
*Tuesday and Friday evenings, plus Sunday afternoon*

Heads-up rule
*Say before a session over an hour, and roughly when it ends.*

When one of us asks for time
*Finish this match, then I'm yours. No new one.*

Our protected evening
*Wednesday, from 7: we cook together*

Phone-free times
*Dinner, and the first 20 minutes in bed*

Chores before the session
*Dishes and our own jobs for the day are done first.*

**YOUR DEAL, READY TO SEND**

Our time-together deal (Jamal and Tess), with each line above. A link holds the deal as it is right now: if either of you changes something, send a new link.

*A made-up example. Names and details are invented.*

Fill in your own: Our time-together deal
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can share a little of yourself, listen well, turn towards the people you love and keep small promises. You can't make someone love you, or love you in the way you want. If closeness keeps hurting you, or you feel afraid, that is not a failure of love on your part. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

THE NEXT FRIDAY, 10:30PM

*This time you leave both phones in the kitchen. You make two cups of tea and ask, "What's something you've been thinking about lately that you haven't told me?" Charlie is quiet for a moment, then talks about their dad getting older, and how scared they are of the phone ringing. You listen, and share your own worry about work. It's midnight before you notice the time. Nothing big was fixed. But you both feel known again.*

## If you're a teenager

First love can be huge and real. So can a first breakup. A *made-up example*: Ines, 16, is dumped by message on a Tuesday night and cries until 2am. "You'll get over it" from an adult doesn't help. What does: telling her cousin, who just listens; muting the chat instead of rereading it; and a rule of no checking their profile after ten. Weeks later she notices a whole day without thinking about it.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I don't need advice, I just need to tell someone." "Can we reply when we can, not all day?" If you're ending it: "I don't want to go out any more. I'm sorry. It isn't about something you did wrong."

## In everyday life

### On your own

Being single, widowed, divorced or happily alone doesn't mean a life without love. Friendships, family, community and the way you treat yourself are all places where love lives. If you want a partner and don't have one, that longing is real and worth being gentle with. See On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) and Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief).

- **Partners:** Most partners drift into talking only about jobs and bills. One real question a week can bring you back. See Turning towards (spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward) and Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins).
- **More than two partners:** Closeness with each person needs its own time and attention. See More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two).
- **Friends:** Friendship is love too, and it needs tending like any other. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).
- **Family:** Parents, children, siblings and grandparents often love each other deeply and say it rarely. A short "I'm glad you're my sister" can mean a lot.
- **Long distance:** Being known can still happen across miles, through small, regular check-ins. See Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance).
- **Different levels of desire:** Very common in long relationships, and nobody's fault. Talk at a calm time, keep some affection that doesn't have to lead anywhere, and remember a kind "no" isn't a rejection of the person. A qualified sex therapist or couples therapist can help. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-15-love-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

- **"Real love means a romantic partner."** Friendship, family and chosen family are real love.
- **"If the spark fades, love is over."** Early intensity usually settles. Many long relationships stay warm, close and lively.
- **"If they loved me, they'd just know what I need."** Nobody reads minds. Saying what helps is a gift, not a failure.
- **"Jealousy proves love."** Feeling jealous is human, and asking for something out of care for the relationship is not control. Checking up without agreement, cutting someone off or punishing them is not love. See signs to look out for.
- **"Intimacy means sex."** Intimacy means being known. It can include physical closeness, or not.
- **"Love should be effortless."** Love usually takes small, steady effort, and that effort is part of what love is.

## If you want to help someone else with this

- **Respect their kind of love.** Don't assume everyone wants a partner, children or one kind of relationship.
- **Be a safe person to tell things to.** Listen without judging, and keep what they share private.
- **After a loss or breakup, keep showing up.** Many people get lots of support for two weeks and then very little.
- **If you're worried about someone's relationship,** stay close and kind rather than criticising their partner. If they seem afraid, gently share Not safe at home?

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm always glad to hear from you." "You don't have to explain your relationship to me. I just want you to be happy and safe."

## When to get more help

- If you feel very lonely or low most days for two weeks or more, talk to a doctor or counsellor.
- If closeness feels frightening, or you keep ending up in relationships that hurt you, a counsellor or therapist can help you understand why.
- Couples, family or relationship counselling can help when you feel stuck, distant or keep having the same fight.
- If someone you love controls you, frightens you, checks your phone, cuts you off from friends or pressures you into anything you don't want, that isn't love. Not safe at home? lists free, private help.
- If you're in danger now, call your local emergency number. Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) can help you take the first step.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

## Reading on the website

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Bonding: how closeness grows (spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding): what research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family and you.
- Turning towards: small daily moments of connection.

- The languages of connection (spreadloveandacceptance.com/languages-of-connection): the different ways people show care.
- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency): why good things fade, and how to keep them alive.
- The library: responsiveness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships), love maps, self-expansion, adult attachment and sharing good news (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).

## More for your situation

- Part Three, Chapter 5: Attachment, trust and belonging (page 61)
- Friends · More than two · Long distance
- Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- On my own · Grief and later life
- Retired together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/retired-together) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Love comes in many forms.** Friends, family, partners, chosen family and the love you give yourself are all real love.
- ✓ **Closeness grows from being known.** You share something real, and the other person responds with understanding and care.
- ✓ **Love changes over time.** Early excitement often settles, and long love can stay warm, close and even exciting.
- ✓ **Love is something you do,** in small ways, every day. It never includes fear or control.

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Chapter 4 · Attachment, trust and belonging** page 61
*Attachment and trust*

**Chapter 1 · Why we get out of tune** page 7
*Staying in tune day to day*

**Book 4 · The work nobody sees** Share the Load
*Noticing the work love does*

**Book 1 · Who you are becoming** Know Yourself Kindly
*Growing as a person inside a relationship*


PUT IT TO USE



**Bonding: how closeness grows**
What research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family and you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding



**Turning towards**
Small daily moments of connection
spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward



**Go deeper (free online)** The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-15-love-in-depth

# 6

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 6 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 17

# Fitting in: groups, influence and culture

*Why fitting in pulls so hard, how groups shape what we say and do, how culture and family set the unwritten rules, and how to stay yourself, and disagree kindly, without losing your place. For anyone in any group: a family, a friendship, a team, a faith, a neighbourhood or a group chat.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. The pull to fit in is old and strong
2. We go along more than we think
3. Authority can lead people a long way
4. "Us and them" forms fast
5. Norms are the rules nobody wrote down
6. Cultures differ, and so do people inside them
7. Every family is a small culture
8. Online groups pull harder and faster
9. You can belong and still be yourself
10. Disagree kindly, and early
11. If you're a teenager
12. In everyday life
13. Common mix-ups
14. If you want to help someone else with this
15. When to get more help
16. Reading on this site
17. More for your situation


IN SHORT:

- **The pull to fit in is old and strong.** Being left out hurts, so we bend to stay in. That's human, not weak.
- **Groups shape us more than we notice:** what we say, what we think is normal, and sometimes what we're willing to do.

- **Cultures and families each have unwritten rules.** They differ a lot, and so do the people inside them.
- **You can belong and still be yourself.** One calm, kind voice saying "I see it differently" often frees others to say so too.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **The rulebook from home** (Part One, Then (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then)) and **House rules for us** (One owner per job) write down the rules nobody wrote down, so a group can choose them instead of just following them. Big idea: *notice the quiet incentives*.
- **The monthly look-back** (Part Two, Chapter V (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5)) is "not a review of either person". That is what lets people speak up early, before the group drifts.

THURSDAY, 9:20PM

*The family group chat is buzzing. Someone has posted a joke about your cousin's new partner, and the laughing faces are piling up. Your thumb hovers. You don't find it funny. You also don't want to be the one who "can't take a joke." Everyone else seems fine with it. You start typing a laughing face.*

We all belong to groups, and we need them. Chapter 5 (page 61) looked at belonging: why we need each other and how trust grows. This chapter looks at the other side: how groups pull on us, why we go along, and how to stay true to yourself while staying connected.

01

## The pull to fit in is old and strong.

For most of human history, being part of a group meant survival. Being left out still feels alarming. In studies by Williams and colleagues (2000), people who were simply left out of an online ball-throwing game, by strangers they would never meet, felt worse and less like they belonged. So we bend to stay in: laughing at jokes, keeping quiet, going along.

*For example*: A new starter at a warehouse laughs at a teasing nickname he dislikes, because he wants to be one of the team.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "Wanting to fit in is normal. I still get to choose what I go along with."

TRY THIS:

Notice one moment this week when you went along with something to fit in. No judging. Just notice.

02

## We go along more than we think.

In Solomon Asch's famous experiments (Asch, 1956), people judged which of three lines matched another line. When the actors around them all gave the same wrong answer, people went along with the group on about a third of the answers, even though the right answer was obvious.

Many never went along at all. Later research, such as a review by Bond and Smith (1996), found the effect is real but varies: it has been smaller in more recent studies, and larger in cultures that put the group first.

*For example*: In a meeting, everyone praises a plan. One woman sees a big problem, but stays quiet. Afterwards, two colleagues tell her they had doubts too.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Would I say this if I were on my own?" "If I'm thinking it, someone else might be too."

TRY THIS:

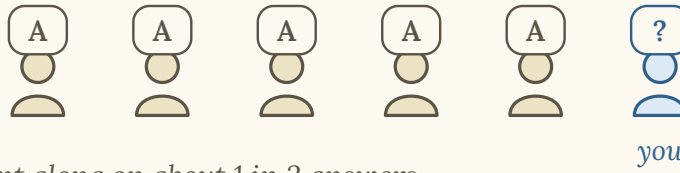
Before a group decision, write down your own view first. Then listen to the group.

## We go along more than we think

*And one other voice changes a lot.*

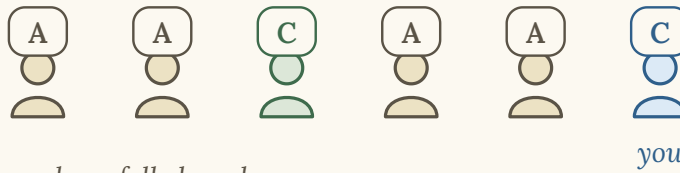



### Alone against the group




*went along on about 1 in 3 answers*

### With one ally




*going along fell sharply*

*One calm, kind voice saying "I see it differently" often frees others to say so too.*

*Asch (1956). About a quarter of people never went along. Across 133 later studies the effect held but varied by time and culture (Bond and Smith, 1996).*

FIGURE 8 We go along more than we think, and one other voice changes a lot. In Asch's studies, going along fell sharply when one other person gave the right answer.

03

## Authority can lead people a long way.

In Stanley Milgram's experiments (Milgram, 1963), many ordinary people kept giving what they believed were painful electric shocks to a stranger, because a man in a lab coat told them to. (No shocks were real.) Burger (2009) repeated part of it safely and found similar results. But the studies are also debated: later researchers, such as Haslam and Reicher (2012), argue people went along when they believed in the cause, not blindly, and many people refused.

*For example*: A nurse is told by a senior doctor to give a dose that looks wrong. She checks, speaks up, and is right. Checking is not disloyalty.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Before I do this, can I check one thing?" "I'm not comfortable with this. Can we look at it again?"

TRY THIS:
Think of one person whose word you tend to follow without question. Is there anything you'd want to check next time?

04

## "Us and them" forms fast.

Part of how we see ourselves comes from our groups: our family, town, team, faith or job. Tajfel and Turner (1979) called this social identity. It brings pride and loyalty. It also makes us quick to favour "us" and to see "them" as all the same, even when the groups are formed on almost nothing. Knowing that this happens is the first step to catching it.

*For example*: Two branches of a family always sit apart at weddings. Nobody quite remembers why. One year, a cousin swaps the

seating plan, and the two sides discover they like the same terrible music.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
"Am I seeing a person, or a group?" "What do we have in common?"

TRY THIS:
Think of a "them" in your life. Name one person from that group as an individual: something they like, something they worry about.

05

### Norms are the rules nobody wrote down.

Every group has norms: what you wear, how you speak, what you laugh at, what you never mention. We often guess the norms wrong. In studies at a university, Prentice and Miller (1993) found that most students were privately less comfortable with heavy drinking than they thought everyone else was. Each person thought they were the odd one out, so everyone kept going along.

*For example:* In an office, everyone answers emails at midnight because they think it's expected. When one manager says, "I don't expect replies after six," relief spreads.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
"Is this really what everyone thinks, or just what everyone does?"

TRY THIS:
Pick one unwritten rule in a group you're in. Ask one person, privately, what they really think of it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

**House rules for us**

*Shona and her son Dexter, 15*

## House rules for us

Person A
*Shona*

Person B
*Dexter*

Date of this list
3 October 2026

### Our rules, and who keeps each one

| Rule | Who keeps it | Why it matters to Shona | Why it matters to Dexter |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Phones charge in the kitchen from 10 on school nights* | *Both (decide together)* | *I sleep better knowing you're not up at 2* | *Fine if it's both our phones, not just mine* |
| *Homework before games, Monday to Thursday* | *Dexter* | *Less nagging from me* | *Weekends are mine, then* |
| *Say where you're going and when you'll be back* | *Both (decide together)* | *So I don't worry* | *Mum does it too, so it's fair* |
| *Friday tea together, no phones at the table* | *Both (decide together)* | *It's my favourite hour of the week* | *Only if I can pick the food sometimes* |

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

**Rules with someone who keeps them**

4 of 4. Every rule has someone who keeps it.

### Changes to the list

| Date | What changed | Who |
|---|---|---|
| 3 Oct 2026 | *Dexter asked for weekends without phone rules. Agreed for a month, then we look again.* | *Shona and Dexter* |

*A made-up example. Names and details are invented. The norms nobody wrote down, written down, with room for both of them to change them.*

Fill in your own: House rules for us (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

06

## Cultures differ, and so do people inside them.

Cultures differ in how much they put the individual or the group first. Researchers call this individualism and collectivism (Hofstede, 1980). In some, "standing out" is admired. In others, fitting in and keeping harmony are signs of maturity. Neither is better. But be careful with labels: a large review by Oyserman and colleagues (2002) found the differences were smaller and less tidy than often claimed, and individuals vary hugely within every culture.

*For example:* A woman raised in a close-knit family moves in with a partner who grew up encouraged to "do your own thing." He sees her daily calls home as clingy; she sees his rare calls as cold. Both are following the rules they learned.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Where I grew up, this was normal. What was normal for you?"

TRY THIS:

Name one thing you think of as simply "how people should behave." Where did you learn it? Might someone else have learned the opposite?

07

## Every family is a small culture.

Families have their own norms: how loud people are, how feelings are shown, who does what, what's talked about and what isn't, how you say sorry, or if you do. We often only notice our family's rules when we live with someone from a different family. Part One looks at the rules you grew up with.

*For example*: Two housemates clash over the kitchen. In one's family, you wash up straight away. In the other's, you wash up in the morning. Neither is lazy or fussy; they grew up in different small cultures.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"In my family we always… What did yours do?" "Shall we make our own rule?"

TRY THIS:

Write three rules from the family you grew up in. Keep one you value, and question one you don't.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

**Family plan card**

*Amaka and Chris, new parents, with Chris's parents*

### Our family plan

A plan for the family, not a list of chores.

Who's in this plan (optional)

*Amaka, Chris, Nana Joy and Grandad Pete*

Visits

*Sunday lunch every other week, 12 to 3. Text the day before.*

Advice
*Ask first: "Do you want ideas, or just to talk?"*

The baby's or children's routines
*Nap at 1. Back to sleep on her back, always. Ask us before any new food.*

A regular job for a grandparent or relative
*Grandad Pete does the Tuesday morning walk with the pram.*

We'll look at this again on
*The first Sunday of December*

ON THE CARD

One topic at a time. We're on the same side.

*A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Two family cultures, one plan written on purpose.*

Fill in your own: Family plan card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins)

08

## Online groups pull harder and faster.

Group chats, forums and social media make group pressure quicker and more public. Likes and replies show the norm instantly. In a study of over half a million posts, Brady and colleagues (2017) found that messages with more moral and emotional words spread further, mostly among people who already agreed. Outrage travels fast; quiet doubts don't.

*For example*: A parents' group chat turns against a teacher after one angry post. A dad who knows the teacher well sends a calm message: "I'd want to hear her side before we decide." Two others agree.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Would I say this to their face?" "The loudest posts aren't the whole group."

TRY THIS:

Before you react to a heated post, wait ten minutes. Then decide whether to reply, reply privately, or not reply at all.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: group chats move fast! Before you send a reply, a helper can read the room with you.

TOOL **Chat analyzer** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

09

## You can belong and still be yourself.

Belonging is being accepted as you are; fitting in is changing to be accepted (see Chapter 5 (page 61)). Good groups have room for difference. It helps to know your own values, to have more than one group, and to have at least one ally. In Asch's experiments, when just one other person gave the right answer, going along with the group dropped sharply.

*For example*: A teenager loves chess but his friends tease it as "nerdy." He joins a chess club as well as keeping his friends. With two groups, neither one can decide who he is.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Which groups let me be fully myself?" "Who would back me up if I spoke?"

TRY THIS:

Write down three things you value. Next time a group pulls you, check: is this in line with them?

10

## Disagree kindly, and early.

You don't have to choose between going along and starting a war. A kind dissent is short, calm, about the issue rather than the people, and leaves room for others. Speaking early is easier than speaking late. And you don't have to do it in front of everyone: a private word often works better.

*For example*: Back to the group chat. Instead of a laughing face, you message your aunt privately: "I know it was meant as a joke, but it might hurt. Could we leave it?" She deletes it.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I see it a bit differently. Can I say why?" "I'm not comfortable with that joke." "I might be the only one, but I'd like us to think again." "Can we hear from people who haven't spoken yet?"

TRY THIS:

Choose one sentence from above that feels like you. Say it out loud a few times, so it's ready when you need it.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Disagreeing early and kindly is easier with the words ready. This workpaper helps you say it so it lands.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can notice the pull to fit in, check what you actually think, choose your groups, and say "I see it differently" kindly.

You can't control what a group does, and you don't have to stay in a group that keeps asking you to hide who you are or go against what's right. If a group, a family or a partner uses pressure, fear or threats to control you, that's not belonging. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help.

THURSDAY, 9:40PM

*You delete the laughing face. Instead, you message your aunt, who posted the joke: "I know it was meant to be funny, but it might hurt if they see it. Could we leave it?" A few minutes later the joke disappears. Then your cousin messages you privately: "Thank you. I saw it before it went. Means a lot." Nobody fell out. The group is still the group. It just has a bit more room in it now.*

## If you're a teenager

Group chats are where a lot of friendship happens, and a lot of hurt. A *made-up example:* Rhys, 15, finds a photo of himself from PE being joked about in his class chat. He doesn't answer back.

He screenshots it, mutes the chat and tells his sister, and they tell his form tutor. Then a girl in his class messages him privately: "That wasn't funny. Sorry I didn't say anything." Most people in a group chat don't like what's happening. They just think everyone else does.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm not okay with this. Please delete it." To a friend: "That wasn't okay. Are you alright?" To an adult: "Something's happening online and I need help with it."

## In everyday life

- **On your own:** Having no group can be as hard as having a pushy one. Look for groups built around something you enjoy, so the belonging comes with the activity. See Chapter 5 (page 61) and casual ties (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).
- **With a partner:** Two families, two sets of rules. Talk about them openly, and make your own. See family scripts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life).
- **Parents and children:** Children and teens feel peer pressure strongly. Help them practise a "no" that saves face. See For teens: friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens).
- **With family:** Old family roles (the joker, the peacekeeper, the black sheep) can be hard to step out of. See Old roles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts).
- **At work:** Teams where people feel safe to speak up make better decisions. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) and the library on teams (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/teams).
- **Online:** Mute, leave or take a break from groups that leave you feeling worse. You're allowed.
- **When everyone agrees too fast:** That's called groupthink. If you lead, share your view last and ask for one risk from each person before deciding. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-17-groups-in-depth).

- **Teams rarely in one room:** Write decisions down, go round everyone before deciding, and keep a short check-in so people at home aren't forgotten. More in the full chapter.

## Common mix-ups

- **"Only weak people conform."** Everyone is influenced by groups. Knowing that makes you more free, not less.
- **"Milgram proved people will do anything they're told."** Many people refused, results varied a lot with the setup, and the studies have real critics. People seem most likely to go along when they believe in the cause.
- **"Culture explains everything about a person."** Culture shapes us, but people vary hugely within every culture. Ask the person, don't assume.
- **"Disagreeing will ruin the relationship."** Calm, kind disagreement often builds trust. Swallowing it for years tends to do more harm.
- **"Fitting in is the same as belonging."** Fitting in means changing to be accepted. Belonging means being accepted as you are.

## If you want to help someone else with this

- **Be the ally.** If someone speaks up, back them up, even quietly: "I think that's a fair point." One ally makes a big difference.
- **Make room.** In any group you lead, invite quieter people and different views: "What haven't we thought of?"
- **Check in privately.** If someone seems to be going along against their wishes, ask gently, away from the group.

- **Watch for exclusion.** Notice who is left out of chats, plans and jokes, and bring them in.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I noticed you went quiet when they said that. Are you okay?"
> "I'd like to hear what you think, even if it's different."

## When to get more help

Group pressure is part of life. It may be time for more help if:

- a group, family or partner controls who you see, what you wear, what you spend or what you believe, or punishes you for disagreeing;
- you feel you can't leave a group without being threatened, shamed or cut off from everyone you know;
- you're being bullied, at school, at work or online;
- being left out or pressured is leaving you very low, anxious or hopeless.

Talk to someone you trust, a counsellor or a doctor. Not safe at home? lists free, private help if someone at home controls or frightens you. For low mood or worry, see Chapter 16 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-16-worry). If you are thinking about ending your life, please tell someone today.

In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

## Reading on the website

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- The wiring card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card): share how you work best, so a group can make room for you.
- Leading a group (spreadloveandacceptance.com/groups): a six-session guide with ground rules that make room for difference.
- The library on teams, including psychological safety.
- The library: family scripts, social comparison, the false consensus effect (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking) and confirmation bias.
- Chapter 4 (page 25) on saying hard things so they land.

## More for your situation

- For teens: friends and pressure
- Family rifts · In-laws
- At work
- For teachers (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-teachers)
- **More in Part Three:** Belonging and trust (page 61) · How we see each other (page 45) · Values (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-10-values)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

### WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **The pull to fit in is old and strong.** Being left out hurts, so we bend to stay in. That's human, not weak.
- ✓ **Groups shape us more than we notice:** what we say, what we think is normal, and sometimes what we're willing to do.
- ✓ **Cultures and families each have unwritten rules.** They differ a lot, and so do the people inside them.
- ✓ **You can belong and still be yourself.** One calm, kind voice saying "I see it differently" often frees others to say so too.

### THIS CONNECTS TO


**Chapter 3 · How we see each other** page 45
*Bias and the stories we tell*

**Chapter 4 · Attachment, trust and belonging** page 61
*Why belonging matters so much*

**Book 2 · Values, meaning and a good life** Heal and Steady
*Holding on to your own values*

**Book 4 · Two kinds of fair** Share the Load
*Agreeing what fair means in your group*


### PUT IT TO USE

**The wiring card**
Share how you work best, so a group can make room for you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

**Leading a group**
A six-session guide with ground rules that make room for difference
spreadloveandacceptance.com/groups

**Go deeper (free online)** The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-17-groups-in-depth

# 7

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 7 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 12

# Helping others well: support without fixing, boundaries, and not burning out

*How to help someone without taking over: asking what they need, listening first, caring without drowning, keeping kind limits, what to do in a crisis, and how to keep going without burning out.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Ask what kind of help they want
2. Listening is a kind of help
3. Fixing it for them can take away their power
4. Care without drowning in their feelings
5. Your limits make your help last
6. Notice when you're running on empty
7. In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help
8. Don't wait for someone else to step in
9. Let other people help you too
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation


IN SHORT:

- **Ask what kind of help they want.** "Ideas, or just someone to listen?" saves a lot of misfires.
- **Listening is help.** Fixing it for someone can take away their power.
- **Your limits make your help last.** Caring from a steady place helps more than drowning in their feelings.

- **In a crisis, stay and bring in help.** It's okay to ask directly about suicide, and to call for help.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **One owner per job: sharing the care** (Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) works because help lasts when it is shared and named. Carers burn out when everything is "just helping" and nobody else owns a job. Big idea: *see the whole load.*
- **How much are you carrying?** (Part Two, Chapter III (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3)) helps you notice when you are running on empty before you snap or stop.

WEDNESDAY, 7:15PM

*Your friend is telling you about her awful week. You have five good ideas before she's finished her first sentence. You share them all. She goes quiet, then says, "Yeah, maybe." You both hang up feeling a bit worse, and you're not sure why.*

Most of us want to help the people around us. But helping well is a skill, and good intentions don't always land. This chapter explains how support works, why "fixing" can backfire, and how to care for others in a way you can keep up. It's for friends, partners, parents, coworkers, carers, neighbours, and anyone who has ever wanted to help and didn't know how.

01

### Ask what kind of help they want.

Help comes in different kinds. Some people want ideas. Some want someone to listen. Some want a practical hand, like a meal or a lift. Some just want company. Giving the wrong kind, even kindly, can leave someone feeling unheard. The simplest fix is to ask.

*For example (a friend)*: In the scene above, a better start would have been: "That sounds like a rotten week. Do you want ideas, or do you just want to vent?" She would have said "vent," and the call would have gone very differently.

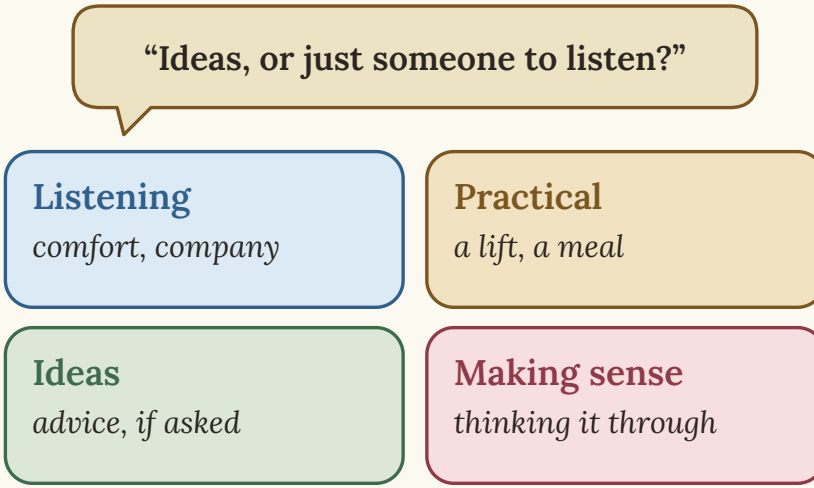
> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Do you want ideas, a listening ear, or a hand with something?"
> "What would help most right now?"

TRY THIS:

Next time someone tells you about a problem, ask what kind of help they want before you give any.

## Ask what kind of help they want

*The wrong kind of help can feel like not being heard.*




- Fixing it for them can take away their power.
- Care from a steady place. Your limits make your help last.
- In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help.

*Kinds of support after House (1981). Support helps most when it fits what the person needs (Cutrona and Russell, 1990), though the evidence for exact matching is mixed.*

FIGURE 9 Ask what kind of help they want. Fixing it for them can take away their power, and your limits make your help last.

02

## Listening is a kind of help.

Being truly heard is powerful. It helps people calm down, think more clearly, and often find their own answers. Good listening means paying attention, not interrupting, checking you understood, and showing that their feelings make sense, even if you'd feel differently.

*For example (partners)*: Ravi comes home upset about his boss. Instead of "Just quit," his partner says: "So he criticised you in front of everyone, after you stayed late all week. No wonder you're furious." Ravi's shoulders drop. Ten minutes later, he has his own plan.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"So what happened was… Have I got that right?" "That makes sense. Anyone would feel that way."

TRY THIS:

In one conversation today, listen for two whole minutes without giving advice. Then sum up what you heard.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: sometimes the best help is sitting close and listening, no fixing needed. Listening takes energy too, so check your own tank now and then.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · free to print · spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

03

## Fixing it for them can take away their power.

When we love someone, we want to make the problem go away. But doing things for people that they could do themselves can leave them feeling less capable. Helping well often means helping someone do it, not doing it for them. It respects that it's their life and their choice.

*For example (a parent and a grown-up child)*: Rosalind's 24-year-old son is struggling with a job application. She wants to rewrite it. Instead she asks, "Want me to read it and tell you what stands out?" He makes the changes himself, and feels proud when he gets the interview.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "Is this mine to fix, or theirs to solve with my support?" "What do they want to do here?"

TRY THIS:
Notice the urge to fix. Before acting, ask: "Would you like me to do that, or help you do it?"

04

## Care without drowning in their feelings.

Feeling someone's pain as if it were your own can wear you out fast. Researchers separate this "empathic distress" from compassion: warm concern from a steadier place. Compassion still cares deeply. It just doesn't require you to sink with the other person. A steady helper is more useful than a second person drowning.

*For example (housemates)*: When Abi's housemate went through a breakup, Abi cried every night with her and couldn't sleep. After a week she was exhausted. She changed approach: kind and present,

but also taking breaks, and reminding herself, "This is her pain. I can care without carrying all of it."

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
"I can be with them in this without making it mine." "I care, and I'm steady."

TRY THIS:
After a heavy conversation, do something that brings you back to yourself: a walk, a shower, five slow breaths. It isn't abandoning them. It's refilling.

05

## Your limits make your help last.

Saying yes to everything isn't kindness in the long run. It leads to resentment, exhaustion and, eventually, not being able to help at all. Limits tell people what you can give, so your yes means something. A kind no, with a suggestion of what you can do, is still help.

*For example (siblings)*: Kojo's sister keeps asking to borrow money. He loves her and he's running out. He says: "I can't lend money any more. I can help you go through your bills on Sunday, if you'd like."

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I can't do that, but I can do this." "I want to help, and I need to stop at nine tonight."

TRY THIS:
Write down one thing you're giving that you can't keep giving. Plan a kinder, smaller version you could offer instead.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your limits keep your help going for longer. When you need to say "not this time", the script maker helps you say no kindly, with something to offer instead.

TOOL **Say no kindly: script maker** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals

06

## Notice when you're running on empty.

People who help a lot, like carers, parents, nurses, teachers and the friend everyone calls, can burn out. Signs include feeling exhausted most of the time, feeling numb or cynical about the people you help, getting ill more often, or dreading the next call. It doesn't mean you're a bad helper. It means you need help too.

*For example (a carer)*: Helen has looked after her husband since his stroke. She snaps at him, then feels terrible. Her doctor says it sounds like carer strain. A local carers' group and a few hours of respite each week give her back a little of herself, and she's gentler at home.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Looking after myself is part of looking after them."

TRY THIS:

Rate your energy from 1 to 10 each evening for a week. If it's often 3 or lower, ask someone for one specific kind of help. See Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers).

07

## In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help.

If someone tells you they're thinking of ending their life, or you're worried they might be, it's okay to ask them directly. Research, such as a review led by Tim Dazzi (2014), suggests asking about suicide doesn't put the idea in someone's head; it can bring relief. You don't have to be their therapist. Your job is to listen, stay with them, and help them reach trained support.

*For example (a coworker)*: A colleague says, "Sometimes I think everyone would be better off without me." Kirsty says gently: "I'm really glad you told me. Are you thinking about ending your life?" She says she's had thoughts. Kirsty stays with her and they call a crisis line together.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Are you thinking about suicide?" "I'm glad you told me. You don't have to go through this alone. Let's call someone together."

TRY THIS:

Save a crisis number in your phone now, so you have it if you ever need it. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If someone is in immediate danger, call your local emergency number.

08

## Don't wait for someone else to step in.

When lots of people see something go wrong, each person can assume someone else will act. Psychologists call this the bystander effect. Knowing about it helps you break it. You don't have to be a

hero. Small, safe actions count: asking "Are you okay?", getting staff, or calling for help.

*For example (a stranger)*: On a train, a man is making a young woman uncomfortable. Yvonne doesn't confront him. She sits next to the woman and asks loudly, "Hi! Is this the train to Leeds?" The woman joins in the chat, and the man moves away.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Are you okay? Do you need anything?" To someone else nearby: "Can you get the driver? I'll stay here."

TRY THIS:

Think of one safe thing you could do if you saw someone in trouble in a public place: distract, get help, or check in afterwards. Having a plan makes it easier to act.

09

### Let other people help you too.

Helping goes both ways. People who are good at giving help are often bad at receiving it. But letting others help is a gift to them, too: most people like being useful to someone they care about. Relationships where only one person ever helps tend to feel uneven over time.

*For example (on your own, as a new parent)*: Nkechi kept saying, "We're fine, thanks," to every offer after the baby came. When she finally said yes to a neighbour's offer of a meal, the neighbour was delighted, and they became friends.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Yes, thank you. That would really help." "Could you do one thing for me this week?"

TRY THIS:

Say yes to the next small offer of help you get, even if you could manage without it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

**One owner per job: sharing the care**

*Margaret and Alan, with their daughter Sue*

## One owner per job: sharing the care

Person A
*Margaret*

Person B
*Alan*

Person C
*Sue*

Date of this list
*6 October 2026*

### Who owns each job

| Job | How often | Roughly how long? | Owner | Helper or backup | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Medicines and the pill box (as the care team directs)* | *Weekly* | 0.5 | *Margaret* | *Sue* | *Sue checks it on Sundays* |
| *Book and go along to medical appointments* | *As needed* | 3 | *Sue* | *Margaret* | *Sue drives; Mum comes too* |
| *Insurance and paperwork* | *Monthly* | 1 | *Alan* | *Sue* | *Dad can do this from his chair* |
| *Night care and night-time calls* | *Daily* | 1 | *Margaret* | | *Ask the nurse about a night sitter* |

| Job | How often | Roughly how long? | Owner | Helper or backup | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Sunday call with the family* | *Weekly* | 0.5 | *Alan* | | |
| *Book respite: a break for the main carer* | *Monthly* | 0.5 | *Sue* | | *Mum's Thursday afternoon off* |
| *Groceries and meals* | *Weekly* | 2 | *Sue* | *Margaret* | *Online shop, Sue orders* |

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

**Jobs with an owner**
7 of 7. Every job has an owner.

**Who's carrying more right now**
Margaret 63% · Alan 9% · Sue 28%. Does this match what you agreed? If it doesn't match, ask which job could move first. It's a starting point for a talk, not a scorecard.

### Changes to the list

| Date | What changed | Who |
|---|---|---|
| 6 Oct 2026 | *Sue takes Tuesday nights from next week, so Margaret gets one full night's sleep.* | *Margaret, Alan and Sue* |

*A made-up example. Names and details are invented. This is about who owns each job, not medical advice.*

Fill in your own: One owner per job (sharing the care)
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can offer help, listen well, and be honest about your limits. You can't make someone accept help, take your advice or get better on your timetable. Their life and their choices are theirs. If someone is in danger, your part is to bring in help, not to carry it alone.

THE NEXT WEDNESDAY, 7:15PM

*Your friend calls again. This time you say, "Rough week? Do you want ideas, or just to talk it out?" She laughs and says, "Just talk." You listen. At the end, she says, "I think I know what I'm going to do." You didn't give her a single idea, and it was the most helpful call you've had in months.*

## In everyday life

- **On your own:** Helping yourself counts too. Ask yourself the same question: "Do I need ideas right now, or just some rest?"
- **With a partner:** "Do you want me to help, or just to hear it?" works at home as well as anywhere.
- **Family:** Caring for a parent or a child with extra needs is long-haul help. Share the load early. See Caring for someone you love.
- **Friends:** The friend everyone calls needs someone to call too. Notice who that might be.
- **At work:** Covering for a struggling coworker is kind for a week. Longer than that, it needs a real conversation with the team. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).
- **With strangers:** In an emergency, point to one person: "You in the blue coat, please call for help." A crowd often waits for

someone else.

- **If you have ADHD:** Helping is interesting and urgent, so a fast "yes" is easy. Try "I'd like to help. Let me check my week and come back to you tonight." And ask for the practical help you need too. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-12-helping-in-depth).

## Common mix-ups

- **"Helping means solving the problem."** Often, helping means listening, being there, or helping someone find their own answer.
- **"If I really cared, I'd feel everything they feel."** Caring from a steady place helps more and lasts longer.
- **"Good helpers never say no."** Good helpers last because they know their limits.
- **"Asking about suicide might give them the idea."** Research suggests it doesn't, and asking can help someone open up.
- **"I'll make it worse if I step in."** There are small, safe ways to help. Doing nothing often feels worse for the person in trouble.
- **"I should be able to manage without help."** Everyone needs help sometimes. Receiving it is part of a healthy relationship.

## If you want to help someone else with this

This whole chapter is about helping others, so here's help for the helpers around you:

- **Notice the helpers.** The carer, the friend everyone calls, the coworker who always covers. Ask them how they are, and mean

it.

- **Offer specific help.** “Can I take the kids on Saturday morning?” is easier to accept than “Let me know if you need anything.”
- **Give them permission to rest.** “You’re allowed a night off. I’ve got this.”
- **If a helper seems burned out,** share Caring for someone you love or suggest they talk to a doctor.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> “You look after everyone. Who looks after you?” “I’d love to do something for you this week. What would help?”

## When to get more help

- **If someone is in danger now,** call your local emergency number.
- **If someone talks about suicide,** stay with them and contact a crisis line together. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines.
- **If someone tells you they’re being hurt or controlled at home,** believe them, don’t confront the other person yourself, and share Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)
- **If you’re burned out as a helper or carer,** talk to your doctor, a carers’ organisation or a counsellor. Respite and support are not luxuries.
- **If helping someone is becoming unsafe for you,** step back and bring in professionals. You can still care from a safer distance.

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins), for tender conversations, and Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask) if you want help finding words.

**Reading pages to read on the website**

- Library: active listening (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication), advice or support? and validation.
- Library: empathic distress and compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection) and social support.
- Library: burnout (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress) and caregiver strain.
- Library: saying no and boundaries.
- Stories from philosophy: the circles of Hierocles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth).

## More for your situation

- **Carers:** Caring for someone you love · When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill)
- **Friends:** Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Parents and grandparents:** For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) · For grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids)
- **At work:** At work · For counsellors, coaches and group leaders (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)
- **After a loss:** Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)

- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

**More in Part Three**

← Chapter 11: Healing after hurt (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing) · Chapter 13: Anger → (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-13-anger) · All chapters in the book's contents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/)

**A limit to keep in mind:** This chapter is about everyday helping. It isn't training in crisis care or therapy. When someone's safety is at risk, the most helpful thing you can do is bring in people trained to help.

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> WHAT TO REMEMBER
>
> - ✓ **Ask what kind of help they want.** "Ideas, or just someone to listen?" saves a lot of misfires.
> - ✓ **Listening is help.** Fixing it for someone can take away their power.
> - ✓ **Your limits make your help last.** Caring from a steady place helps more than drowning in their feelings.
> - ✓ **In a crisis, stay and bring in help.** It's okay to ask directly about suicide, and to call for help.

## THIS CONNECTS TO

**Book 4 · The work nobody sees**
*The care work nobody sees* — Share the Load

**Book 4 · Is the split working?**
*Sharing the load so it lasts* — Share the Load

**Book 2 · Loss, grief and big life changes**
*Helping someone through grief* — Heal and Steady

**Book 2 · Stress and the nervous system**
*Noticing your own stress first* — Heal and Steady

## PUT IT TO USE



**Check-ins**
For tender conversations, and Professor Puddles if you want help finding words
spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins



**Stories from philosophy: the circles of Hierocles**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth



**Go deeper (free online)** The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-12-helping-in-depth

# Workpapers and tools in this book

*Every workpaper and tool the chapters point to, in two separate lists, with the chapters that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.*

## Workpapers mentioned in this book

*Pages to fill in, on your own or together.*

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02
In: Helping others well (page 117)

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03
In: Groups, influence and culture (page 97), Helping others well (page 117)

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09
In: Why we get out of tune (page 7), How communication works (page 25), Groups, influence and culture (page 97)

WORKPAPER WP-13 **The 90-second daily check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-13
In: Why we get out of tune (page 7)

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15
In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page 61), Closeness and love (page 79)

## Tools mentioned in this book

*Interactive helpers to use on the site.*

TOOL **Chat analyzer** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator
In: How communication works (page 25), How we see each other (page 45), Groups, influence and culture (page 97)

TOOL **After a talk went wrong: a step-by-step reset** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

In: Why we get out of tune (page 7), How communication works (page 25), How we see each other (page 45)

TOOL **Say no kindly: script maker** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals

In: Helping others well (page 117)

TOOL **Make a pause plan for arguments** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw

In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page 61)

TOOL **Weekly check-in card** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

In: How communication works (page 25), Closeness and love (page 79), Groups, influence and culture (page 97), Helping others well (page 117)

TOOL **Get one small bonding idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page 61), Closeness and love (page 79)

TOOL **What feels like care to me: a care card** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

In: Closeness and love (page 79)

TOOL **How I like to be spoken to: a one-page card** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

In: How communication works (page 25), Groups, influence and culture (page 97)

TOOL **Compare your daily rhythms** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration

In: Why we get out of tune (page 7)

TOOL **Upset right now? A 5-minute calm-down** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

In: How communication works (page 25), Attachment, trust and belonging (page 61), Closeness and love (page 79)

TOOL **Ask a question in your own words** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

In: Helping others well (page 117)

TOOL **Handoff-bag checklist for two homes** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

In: How communication works (page 25), How we see each other (page 45)

TOOL **Room agreement for roommates** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room`

In: How communication works (page 25)

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TOOL **10-minute team check-in** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/work`

In: How we see each other (page 45), Attachment, trust and belonging (page 61), Groups, influence and culture (page 97), Helping others well (page 117)

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TOOL **Connect two fields of study** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath`

In: Why we get out of tune (page 7)

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# Words used in this book

*The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.*

### Battery

Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, your load: a higher load score means a heavier load, and a lower battery.

### A bid

A bid is any small reach for attention or connection, like "look at this," a sigh or a joke.

### Calm-Down Kit

The Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

### Carrier wave

The carrier wave is the feeling that travels underneath the words: the tone that arrives before the meaning does.

### Check-in

A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

### Complacency

Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

### Double empathy

The idea, from the autistic researcher Damian Milton, that misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people run both ways: each finds the other hard to read, so neither side is simply "missing" something.

### Drift

Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

### Flooded

Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

### Frequency

Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

### Groupthink

When a close group wants agreement so much that doubts go unsaid and a poor decision goes ahead. Irving Janis named it in 1972.

### A kind no

A kind no says what you can and can't do right now, without blaming anyone.

### Kinship care

When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

### The ladder

Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. Today's Weather calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

### The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

### Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

### Pressure

Pressure, in Today's Weather, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

### Psychological safety

A shared sense in a group or team that you can speak up, ask a question or admit a mistake without being punished or embarrassed (Amy Edmondson).

### Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

### Retune

To retune is to notice you've fallen out of step with someone and adjust together: slower, softer, or at a better time.

### The rulebook from home

The rulebook from home is the unwritten set of rules you grew up with, about love, upset, chores and rest, that you may still expect others to follow.

### Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

### Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?: a load score from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 to 0.59 moderate, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

### Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

### Today's Weather

Today's Weather is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

### Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

### Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

### Workpaper

A workpaper is a short worksheet. Each person fills in their own, then you read them together.

### Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

# Research notes



The 125 studies and books these chapters mention, in short. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online: `spreadloveandacceptance.com/research`.

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*For what you want to remember, try or ask about.*